

The pair singular series of a polynomial III: the off-diagonal in Cesàro form

Jasper Reichardt*

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Abstract

For an irreducible quadratic f with pair singular series $S_f(h)$ and Bateman–Horn constant $C(f)$, parts I and II reduced the conjecture $\sum_{h \leq H} (1 - h/H)(S_f(h) - C(f)^2) = -\frac{1}{2}C(f)\log H + A_f + o(1)$ to a statement about the pairs of distinct roots of f modulo squarefree d (“Hypothesis (E)”), and showed that in Cesàro form any unbounded saving over the trivial bound suffices. This paper takes Hypothesis (E) apart. We prove an exact decomposition of the Cesàro off-diagonal into pieces indexed by the part u of the modulus on which the two roots agree: piece u is the same problem with length H/u and with the roots of $x^2 \equiv D$ replaced by the roots of $u^2x^2 \equiv D$, a dilation by u^{-1} , and all pieces carry equal weight per unit of $\log u$. The main result is that the off-diagonal is not small: the pieces with $u > H^{2/3}$, where the dilations average out along u , leave a main term $c_{\text{off}}(f)H$ with an explicit negative constant, $-\log p/(p-1)$ per split prime modulus, and this constant predicts the mean of the sharp off-diagonal to three digits against exact data to 10^7 for four quadratics. Two further parts are unconditional: the piece $u = 1$, by the theorem of Duke, Friedlander and Iwaniec on Weyl sums for quadratic roots converted from smooth to sharp cut-offs; and the moduli below the length in every piece, by Koksma’s inequality and a weighted form of the Chinese-remainder equidistribution of Kowalski and Soundararajan, whose local input is the same for every dilation. What remains is one window in each piece with $1 < u \leq H^{2/3}$, the moduli between the length and u^2 times the length, where an interval covers less than a period and a logarithmic saving is not enough. We give its exact Fourier form, show that a Weyl-sum hypothesis (Hypothesis W, a bound $(uk)^B t^\theta$ for the Weyl sums of the dilated roots at frequency k over moduli up to t) closes it exactly when $\theta + 6B < 1$, so that any power saving in the modulus suffices but the loss in the frequency and the dilation must be almost nil, and prove the Cesàro form of Conjecture 1, constant included, under that hypothesis. Over $\mathbb{F}_q[u]$ we prove that the off-diagonal has a main term: for $f = t^2 - u$ and the two smallest lengths, $\text{Off}_f(N) = -2/q + O(q^{-3/2})$; a configuration count predicts, and exact computations for three discriminants and $q \leq 43$ confirm, that the generic value is $-1/q$, the weight of the excluded diagonal pairs at the first degree above the cut-off, the value $-2/q$ being a small-length effect.

1 Introduction

In plain terms. Prime values of a polynomial are correlated through the small primes. Part I turned the size of that correlation into an exact identity whose main part, coming from equal roots of f modulo d , is understood, and whose remaining part, coming from pairs of distinct roots, is a question about how the square roots of the discriminant modulo composite numbers are distributed. This paper shows that the remaining part is a sum of copies of one problem, one copy for each way the two roots can agree on a part of the modulus; that the copies are

*Independent researcher. Correspondence: jasperreichardt@gmail.com.

of equal importance; that the first copy is a theorem of Duke, Friedlander and Iwaniec; that in every copy the moduli shorter than the length are handled by a general mixing property of the Chinese remainder theorem; that the copies with a large agreeing part average out to an explicit main term, which we compute and confirm numerically; and that what is left is, in each copy, the moduli just above the length, where an interval covers less than one period, and where a genuinely stronger estimate is needed. We state that estimate precisely and say what strength it must have. Over polynomial rings the same object has an explicit main term too, which we compute.

Set-up. Let $f = t^2 + bt + c \in \mathbb{Z}[t]$ be irreducible, without fixed prime divisor, with discriminant $D = b^2 - 4c$ (not a square). For a prime p let $\omega(p) = \omega_f(p)$ be the number of roots of f modulo p : $\omega(p) = 2$ if $p \nmid 2D$ and D is a square modulo p (*split*), 0 if D is a non-square (*inert*), and ≤ 1 if $p \mid 2D$ (*special*). All moduli below are squarefree. Put

$$\lambda(p) = \frac{p}{p - 2\omega(p)}, \quad P_p = 1 - \frac{\omega(p)^2}{(p - \omega(p))^2}, \quad P(1) = \prod_p P_p,$$

$$W_f(d) = \frac{P(1)\lambda(d)}{d}, \quad w(u) = u\omega(u)W_f(u) = P(1)\lambda(u)\omega(u),$$

λ multiplicative; this is the weight of part I, $W_f(d) = db(d) \prod_{p \nmid d} P_p$ with $b(p) = (p - \omega(p))^{-2}$, since $pb(p)/P_p = 1/(p - 2\omega(p))$. If $\omega(2) = 1$ (as for $t^2 + 1$) then $P_2 = 0$ and $\lambda(2)$ is undefined; in that case every d in the support of W_f is even, $W_f(d) = \prod_{p \mid d} p(p - \omega(p))^{-2} \prod_{p \nmid d} P_p$, and all statements below hold verbatim with the weight $w(u) = u\omega(u)W_f(u)$ (which is then supported on even u), the only property used being $W_f(ud') = W_f(u)\lambda(d')/d'$ for d' split and coprime to u . In every case w is a constant multiple of a multiplicative function on squarefree integers, up to a shift by 2: with g multiplicative, $g(p) = \lambda(p)\omega(p)$ for odd p (so $g(p) = p/(p - 2)$ at a special odd prime with $\omega(p) = 1$, and $g(p) = 0$ where $\omega(p) = 0$), we have $w(u) = c_f g(u)$ for all u if $\omega(2) \neq 1$ (with $g(2) = \lambda(2)\omega(2)$), and $w(2u') = c_f g(u')$ for odd u' , $w(u) = 0$ for odd u , if $\omega(2) = 1$. We write $\lambda\omega$ for g when the distinction is immaterial. Every sum over u below is either a sum of g or, in the second case, the same sum over $u' = u/2$; since the moduli d' are odd, the two cases differ only by the constant c_f and the normalisation of the mean value, and we treat the first case in the proofs. One sign deserves notice: $\lambda(3) = -3$ and $P_3 = -3$ when $\omega(3) = 2$ (as for $t^2 + 2$ or $2t^2 + 1$), so the weights are not always positive. All upper bounds below are bounds for absolute values and use $|\lambda|$, $|w|$; Proposition 4 is applied to $|w|$; and the mean value m of g in (12) is nonzero but may be negative. Nothing else depends on the sign. For d coprime to $2D$ let $R_d = \{r \bmod d : r^2 \equiv D\}$ (so $|R_d| = \omega(d)$), the roots of f being $s = (r - b)/2$. Write $\langle x \rangle_d \in [1, d]$ for the representative of $x \bmod d$, and, for a length $Y > 0$ and a residue m ,

$$B_d^{(Y)}(m) = \sum_{\substack{h \leq Y \\ h \equiv m \pmod{d}}} (Y - h) - \frac{Y^2}{2d}. \quad (1)$$

Part I, Theorem 6, proved that with $C = C(f)$

$$\sum_{h \leq H} \left(1 - \frac{h}{H}\right) (S_f(h) - C^2) = -\frac{1}{2}C \log H + O_f(1) + \frac{C^2}{H} \text{Off}_f^*(H),$$

$$\text{Off}_f^*(H) = \sum_d W_f(d) \sum_{\substack{s, s' \text{ roots of } f \bmod d \\ s \neq s'}} B_d^{(H)}(s' - s), \quad (2)$$

the series converging absolutely, and that $\text{Off}_f^*(H) \ll H \log H$ trivially. *Hypothesis (E)* in Cesàro form is $\text{Off}_f^*(H) = o(H \log H)$; it implies Conjecture 1 of part I in Cesàro form with the

leading term $-\frac{1}{2}C(f)\log H$ (part I, Theorem 6(ii) and Remark 7, since the Galois group S_2 is 2-transitive).

Results.

- *Decomposition* (Proposition 1): $\text{Off}_f^*(H) = P(1) \sum_u \lambda(u) \omega(u) \mathcal{P}_u(H/u)$, the sum over squarefree u with $\omega(u) \geq 1$, where the piece $\mathcal{P}_u(Y)$ is the sum (2) with H replaced by Y and the roots $R_{d'}$ replaced by the roots $R_{d'}^{(u)}$ of $u^2 x^2 \equiv D$, over moduli d' coprime to u all of whose primes are split. Each piece is $\ll Y$, and $\sum_u \lambda(u) \omega(u) H/u \asymp H \log H$.
- *The first piece* (Theorem 9): $\mathcal{P}_1(Y) \ll Y^{1-\delta}$ unconditionally when D is a fundamental discriminant covered by [1]; the input is a sharp-cut-off form of their Weyl-sum bound (Lemma 8).
- *Far moduli* (Lemma 7): in piece u the moduli $d' > u^2 Y L$ contribute $O(Y/(u^2 L))$, by a trivial count; no reflection argument is needed.
- *Large agreeing part* (Theorem 12): $\sum_{u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}} w(u) \mathcal{P}_u(H/u) = c_{\text{off}}(f)H + O(H^{1-\delta})$, by averaging the dilations along u (the input is the distribution of $\lambda\omega$ in arithmetic progressions), with the explicit constant $c_{\text{off}}(f) = -\sum_{p \text{ split}} \lambda(p) M_p \log p / (p(p-1)) < 0$ (Lemma 11: the dilation average of the Cesàro weight is $-\log p / (p-1)$ for a prime modulus and 0 for a composite one). For $t^2 + 1$, $c_{\text{off}} = -0.13439$; the mean of the sharp off-diagonal $\text{Off}_f(t)$ to 10^7 is -0.0098 ± 0.0007 against the predicted $c_{\text{off}} + (1 - D_f(1))/2 = -0.00978$ (Corollary 13).
- *Small moduli of every piece* (Theorem 6): the part of $\mathcal{P}_u(Y)$ from moduli $d' \leq Y$ is $\ll Y(\log Y)^{-c}$ uniformly in u , by Koksma's inequality and a weighted version of the Chinese-remainder equidistribution theorem of Kowalski and Soundararajan [3] (Proposition 4). Hence the small-moduli part of Off_f^* is $o(H \log H)$ unconditionally.
- *The window* (§5): unconditionally (Theorem 14)

$$\text{Off}_f^*(H) = c_{\text{off}}H + \sum_{u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}} w(u) \mathcal{W}_u(H/u; \log H) + O(H(\log H)^{1-c}),$$

where the window $\mathcal{W}_u$ collects the moduli $d' \in (Y, u^2 Y \log H]$ of piece u , on which the interval $[1, Y]$ is shorter than the period. The window is the core of Hypothesis (E): a logarithmic saving there is not enough. We give its exact finite Fourier expansion (Lemma 16), which has $u^2 \log H$ frequencies of full weight per modulus, and prove (Theorem 19) that Hypothesis W(θ, B), a Weyl-sum bound $\ll (uk)^B t^\theta$ for the dilated roots, gives $\text{Off}_f^*(H) = c_{\text{off}}H + O(H^{1-\delta})$, hence the Cesàro form of Conjecture 1 with $A_f = A_f^{\text{diag}} + C(f)^2 c_{\text{off}}(f)$, provided $\theta + 6B < 1$. Any $\theta < 1$ is admissible with $B = 0$; the exponents $(\frac{3}{4}, \frac{1}{4})$ of [1] are excluded by their frequency dependence, not by the modulus exponent (Remark 20).

- *Function field* (Theorem 22): for $f = t^2 - u$ over $\mathbb{F}_q[u]$ and $N \in \{1, 2\}$, $\text{Off}_f(N) = -2/q + O(q^{-3/2})$; Conjecture 25: $\text{Off}_f(N) = -1/q + O(q^{-3/2})$ whenever $\max(2N - 2, \deg D) \geq N + 1$, i.e. for all $N \geq 3$ and for $N \leq 2$ when $\deg D > N$, and $-2/q$ otherwise.

What is new relative to Hooley. The decomposition into pieces is implicit in Hooley's treatment of $\sum_{n \leq x} \tau(n^2 + a)$ [2], whose sum Σ_5 is our Off with the weight $1/k$ and whose Lemma 5 handles the phase that our piece $u = 1$ carries; what is new is the identification of the pieces $u > 1$ as dilated copies, their equal weight, the averaging argument for large u and the main term $c_{\text{off}}H$ it produces, the unconditional treatment of the small moduli of every piece, the

precise statement of what remains with the exponents it requires, and the function-field main term.

2 The exact decomposition

For squarefree d coprime to $2D$, the roots of f modulo d are $s = (r - b)/2$, $r \in R_d$, and $R_d = \prod_{p|d} R_p$ by the Chinese remainder theorem, each R_p being $\{\pm r_p\}$. Two roots $s \neq s'$ therefore agree exactly on a divisor $u \mid d$ and differ exactly on $d' = d/u > 1$, where every prime of d' is split; and on d' we have $r' \equiv -r$, so $s' - s \equiv -r \pmod{d'}$ and $s' - s \equiv 0 \pmod{u}$. Let $\bar{u}$ denote the inverse of u modulo d' . Then $s' - s \equiv u\bar{u} \cdot (-r) \pmod{d}$, i.e.

$$\langle s' - s \rangle_d = u \langle -\bar{u}r \rangle_{d'}. \quad (3)$$

If d has a special prime p ($\omega(p) = 1$) the two roots agree at p , so $p \mid u$; inert primes do not divide d at all ($\omega(d) = 0$). Define, for squarefree u with $\omega(u) \geq 1$ and squarefree d' coprime to u with all primes split,

$$R_{d'}^{(u)} = \{-\bar{u}r \bmod d' : r \in R_d\} = \{x \bmod d' : u^2 x^2 \equiv D \pmod{d'}\},$$

the roots of the fixed quadratic $Q_u(x) = u^2 x^2 - D$ modulo d' (the equality because $x \mapsto -\bar{u}x$ is a bijection $R_{d'} \rightarrow R_{d'}^{(u)}$ when $(u, d') = 1$), and the piece

$$\mathcal{P}_u(Y) = \sum_{d'} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \sum_{x \in R_{d'}^{(u)}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}). \quad (4)$$

Proposition 1 (pieces). *For every $H \geq 1$,*

$$\text{Off}_f^*(H) = \sum_u w(u) \mathcal{P}_u(H/u), \quad w(u) = u \omega(u) W_f(u),$$

the sum over squarefree $u \geq 1$ with $\omega(u) \geq 1$, every series converging absolutely. Moreover $\mathcal{P}_u(Y) \ll_f Y$ uniformly in u , $\sum_{u \leq t} |w(u)| \ll t$, and $\sum_{u \leq H} |w(u)|/u \asymp \log H$.

Proof. Fix $d = ud'$ as above. For $m = u\mu$ with $\mu \in [1, d']$ we have, writing $h = uh'$,

$$B_{ud'}^{(H)}(u\mu) = \sum_{\substack{h' \leq H/u \\ h' \equiv \mu \pmod{d'}}} (H - uh') - \frac{H^2}{2ud'} = u B_{d'}^{(H/u)}(\mu).$$

The ordered pairs (s, s') of distinct roots modulo d with agreeing part u are in bijection with pairs (s, d') , and by (3) their difference is $u \langle -\bar{u}r \rangle_{d'}$ where r is the d' -component of $2s + b$; as s runs over the $\omega(u)\omega(d')$ roots, r runs $\omega(u)$ times over $R_{d'}$. Hence

$$\sum_{s \neq s'} B_d^{(H)}(s' - s) = \sum_{\substack{d' \mid d, d' > 1 \\ d' \text{ split}}} \omega(u) u \sum_{r \in R_{d'}} B_{d'}^{(H/u)}(\langle -\bar{u}r \rangle_{d'}),$$

and with $W_f(ud') = P(1)\lambda(u)\lambda(d')/(ud')$ the claimed formula follows by summing over d ; absolute convergence is inherited from (2), all terms being regrouped without change of absolute value. For the bound on $\mathcal{P}_u(Y)$: if $d' \leq Y$ then, by the formula $B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m) = -Ym/d' + m^2/(2d') + Y/2 - m/2 + (d'/2)\phi(\{(Y - m)/d'\})$ of part I (proof of Theorem 6; $\phi(\theta) = \theta - \theta^2$), valid for $1 \leq m \leq d' \leq Y$, the terms linear in m cancel between m and $d' - m$, and $B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m) + B_{d'}^{(Y)}(d' - m) = -m(d' - m)/d' + \frac{d'}{2}(\phi(\{\frac{Y-m}{d'}\}) + \phi(\{\frac{Y+m}{d'}\})) \in [-d'/4, d'/4]$; since

$R_{d'}^{(u)}$ is symmetric, $|\sum_{x \in R_{d'}^{(u)}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'})| \leq \omega(d')d'/8$ (individual values $B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m)$ can be as large as $Y/2$; the symmetry of the root set is used throughout). This gives $\sum_{d' \leq Y} \lambda(d')\omega(d') \ll Y$ by Shiu's theorem, since $\lambda\omega$ is multiplicative with $\lambda\omega(p) \leq 2p/(p-4)$ on split primes and 0 on inert ones, of mean value $\asymp 1$. If $d' > Y$ then $B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m) = (Y-m)^+ - Y^2/(2d')$ for $m \in [1, d']$; the second term contributes $\ll Y^2 \sum_{d' > Y} \lambda(d')\omega(d')/d'^2 \ll Y$, and the first contributes $\sum_{x \leq Y} (Y-x) \sum_{d' > Y, d'|Q_u(x)} \lambda(d')/d'$; since $\sum_{d' > Y, d'|n} 1/d' \leq n^{-1} \sum_{e|n, e < n/Y} e$, and on average over $x \leq Y$, $\sum_{e < n/Y, e|Q_u(x)} e \leq \sum_{e < u^2 Y} e \rho_u(e) \mathbf{1}_{e|Q_u(x)}$ has mean $\ll \sum_{e < u^2 Y} \rho_u(e) \ll u^2 Y$ ($\rho_u(e) \leq \omega(e)$ the number of roots of Q_u modulo e , of mean value $\ll 1$), while $Q_u(x) \gg u^2 x^2$, the first term is $\ll \sum_{x \leq Y} (Y-x) Y/x^2 \cdot \mathbf{1}_{Q_u(x) > Y} + \sum_{x \leq \sqrt{Y}/u} Y \ll Y$. Finally $\sum_{u \leq t} |w(u)| \ll t$ and $\sum_{u \leq H} |w(u)|/u \asymp \log H$ because $|g|$ has a positive mean value on squarefree integers (its Dirichlet series is $\zeta(s)L(s, \chi_D) \times$ an absolutely convergent product near $s = 1$). $\square$

In words. The off-diagonal is a sum over u of the same object, evaluated at length H/u , for the roots of $u^2 x^2 \equiv D$ instead of $x^2 \equiv D$; since $\sum_u w(u)/u$ grows like $\log H$ while each piece is $O(H/u)$, the pieces are equally important on a logarithmic scale, and no range of u can be discarded. The dilation by $\bar{u}$ is the whole difficulty: for $u = 1$ the roots are those of a fixed fundamental quadratic; for $u > 1$ they are those of a quadratic whose discriminant $4u^2 D$ grows with u , and existing theorems degrade with the discriminant.

3 Reduction of a piece to Weyl sums

Fix u and write Y for the length, $R_{d'}^{(u)} = R_{d'}^{(u)}$, $\rho(d') = |R_{d'}^{(u)}|$. Split $\mathcal{P}_u(Y) = \mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(Y) + \mathcal{P}_u^{>}(Y)$ according to $d' \leq Y$ or $d' > Y$.

3.1 Small moduli: Fourier expansion and partial summation

For $d' \leq Y$ and $m \in [1, d']$, with $\phi(\theta) = \theta - \theta^2$ (part I, proof of Theorem 6),

$$B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m) = -\frac{Ym}{d'} + \frac{m^2}{2d'} + \frac{Y}{2} - \frac{m}{2} + \frac{d'}{2} \phi\left(\left\{\frac{Y-m}{d'}\right\}\right),$$

and summing over the symmetric set $R_{d'}^{(u)}$ ($x \in R' \Rightarrow -x \in R'$, so m and $d' - m$ occur together) gives $\sum_{x \in R'} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) = \sum_{\{x, -x\}} \left[-\frac{m(d'-m)}{d'} + \frac{d'}{2} (\phi(\{\frac{Y-m}{d'}\}) + \phi(\{\frac{Y+m}{d'}\})) \right]$. Since $\phi(\{\theta\}) = \frac{1}{6} - \pi^{-2} \sum_{k \geq 1} k^{-2} \cos 2\pi k\theta$ and $\frac{1}{6} - \theta(1-\theta) = \pi^{-2} \sum_{k \geq 1} k^{-2} \cos 2\pi k\theta$,

$$\sum_{x \in R_{d'}^{(u)}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) = \frac{d'}{2\pi^2} \sum_{k \geq 1} \frac{1}{k^2} (1 - \cos \frac{2\pi k Y}{d'}) \rho_k(d'), \quad \rho_k(d') = \sum_{x \in R_{d'}^{(u)}} e\left(\frac{kx}{d'}\right), \quad (5)$$

an absolutely convergent expansion for each d' ($\rho_k(d')$ is real by symmetry). Hence

$$\mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(Y) = \frac{1}{2\pi^2} \sum_{k \geq 1} \frac{1}{k^2} T_k(Y), \quad T_k(Y) = \sum_{d' \leq Y} \lambda(d') \rho_k(d') (1 - \cos \frac{2\pi k Y}{d'}), \quad (6)$$

where now the interchange is legitimate because d' ranges over a finite set, and trivially $|T_k(Y)| \leq 2 \sum_{d' \leq Y} \lambda \rho \ll Y$.

Lemma 2 (from sharp Weyl sums to twisted sums). *Suppose that for some $\theta < 1$, $B \geq 0$ and all $k \geq 1$, $t \geq 2$,*

$$S_k(t) := \sum_{d' \leq t} \lambda(d') \rho_k(d') \ll (uk)^B t^\theta. \quad (7)$$

Then for every $Y_0 \in [1, Y]$,

$$T_k(Y) \ll Y_0 \log Y_0 + (uk)^B (Y^\theta + kY Y_0^{\theta-1}) \log Y.$$

In particular, with $Y_0 = (kY)^{1/(2-\theta)}$, $T_k(Y) \ll (uk)^B (kY)^{1/(2-\theta)} \log Y$.

Proof. The moduli $d' \leq Y_0$ contribute at most $2 \sum_{d' \leq Y_0} \lambda \rho \ll Y_0 \log Y_0$ (crudely). On a dyadic block $V < d' \leq 2V$, $V \geq Y_0$, partial summation against S_k with the function $g(t) = 1 - \cos(2\pi kY/t)$, which satisfies $|g| \leq 2$ and $|g'(t)| \leq 2\pi kY/t^2$, gives $|\sum_{V < d' \leq 2V} \lambda \rho_k g| \leq |S_k(2V)g(2V)| + |S_k(V)g(V)| + \int_V^{2V} |S_k(t)g'(t)| dt \ll (uk)^B V^\theta (1 + kY/V)$. Summing over the dyadic $V \in [Y_0, Y]$ gives the claim. $\square$

In words. The phase $\cos(2\pi kY/d')$ oscillates in d' once $d' \ll kY$, and the cost of integrating it against a partial sum with a power saving is a factor kY/d' ; the small moduli, where that factor is large, are handled trivially, and the balance point $Y_0 = (kY)^{1/(2-\theta)}$ leaves a power saving. Nothing more than a sharp-cut-off Weyl bound with polynomial dependence on the frequency is used.

3.2 Small moduli without the phase: Koksma and the mixing of the Chinese remainder theorem

The Fourier route makes the phase $\cos(2\pi kY/d')$ appear; the discrepancy route does not. For $d' \leq Y$ and the symmetric set $R'_{d'}$, the identity before (5) reads

$$\sum_{x \in R'_{d'}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) = \frac{d'}{2} \sum_{x \in R'_{d'}} \Psi_{Y/d'}\left(\left\{\frac{x}{d'}\right\}\right), \quad \Psi_\eta(\theta) = -\theta(1-\theta) + \frac{1}{2}(\phi(\{\eta - \theta\}) + \phi(\{\eta + \theta\})),$$

and Ψ_η has mean 0 on $[0, 1)$ and total variation ≤ 3 , uniformly in η . Koksma's inequality therefore gives

$$\left| \sum_{x \in R'_{d'}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) \right| \leq \frac{3}{2} d' \omega(d') \text{disc}(\Delta_{d'}^{(u)}), \quad (8)$$

where $\Delta_{d'}^{(u)}$ is the probability measure $\omega(d')^{-1} \sum_{x \in R'_{d'}} \delta_{\{x/d'\}}$ and disc its discrepancy, $\sup_I |\Delta(I) - |I||$ over intervals $I \subset \mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$. The point is that (8) does not see the length Y at all.

We shall need a weighted form of Rankin's bound for smooth numbers, with Dickman-type decay.

Lemma 3 (weighted smooth numbers). *Let $w \geq 0$ be multiplicative, supported on squarefree integers, with $w(p) \leq C_0$ for all primes p , where $C_0 \geq 1$. There are an absolute constant z_0 and $u_0 = 16eC_0^2$ such that for $z \geq z_0$, $X \geq 1$ and $u := \log X / \log z \in [u_0, \log z]$,*

$$\sum_{\substack{s > X \\ P^+(s) \leq z}} \frac{w(s)}{s} \leq \exp\left(-\frac{u \log u}{2}\right) \prod_{p \leq z} \left(1 + \frac{w(p)}{p}\right).$$

Proof. For $\delta > 0$ (Rankin), the sum is at most $X^{-\delta} \sum_{P^+(s) \leq z} w(s) s^{\delta-1} = X^{-\delta} \prod_{p \leq z} (1 + w(p)p^{\delta-1})$, and $1 + ap^\delta \leq (1+a) \exp(a(p^\delta - 1))$ for $a \geq 0$ gives

$$\prod_{p \leq z} \left(1 + \frac{w(p)}{p^{1-\delta}}\right) \leq \prod_{p \leq z} \left(1 + \frac{w(p)}{p}\right) \exp(C_0 E), \quad E = \sum_{p \leq z} \frac{p^\delta - 1}{p}.$$

Put $\lambda = \delta \log z$ and $g(v) = (e^{\delta v} - 1)/v$, an increasing function of $v > 0$, so that $(p^\delta - 1)/p = g(\log p) \log p/p$. With $S(t) = \sum_{p \leq t} \log p/p = \log t + R(t)$, $|R(t)| \leq R_0$ for $t \geq 2$ (Mertens), Stieltjes integration gives

$$\begin{aligned} E &= \int_{2^-}^z g(\log t) dS(t) = \int_{\log 2}^{\log z} g(v) dv + \int_{2^-}^z g(\log t) dR(t) \\ &\leq \int_0^\lambda \frac{e^s - 1}{s} ds + 3R_0 g(\log z) + g(\log 2) \log 2, \end{aligned}$$

where we used that g is increasing to bound $\int R dg$. Since $(e^s - 1)/s \leq e^s$, the integral is $\leq e^\lambda$; the second term is $\leq 3R_0 e^\lambda / \log z$; and $g(\log 2) \log 2 = 2^\delta - 1 \leq 1$ as $\delta \leq 1$ (because $\lambda \leq \log u \leq \log \log z$). Hence $E \leq 2e^\lambda$ once $\log z \geq 6R_0$ and $e^\lambda \geq 2$. Now choose $\lambda = \log u - \log(4C_0)$, which is $\geq \log 4$ for $u \geq 16C_0$ and is $\leq \log u \leq \log z$ as required: then $e^\lambda = u/(4C_0)$, so $C_0 E \leq u/2$, while $\delta \log X = \lambda u = u \log u - u \log(4C_0)$. The exponent is therefore at most $-u \log u + u \log(4C_0) + u/2 \leq -\frac{1}{2}u \log u$ as soon as $\frac{1}{2} \log u \geq \log(4C_0) + \frac{1}{2}$, i.e. $u \geq 16eC_0^2$. $\square$

Proposition 4 (weighted Kowalski–Soundararajan). *Let $(A_p)_p$ be a family of subsets $A_p \subset \mathbb{Z}/p$, $\rho(p) = |A_p|$, let Q be the set of squarefree q all of whose prime factors have $\rho(p) \geq 1$, and for $q \in Q$ let $A_q \subset \mathbb{Z}/q$ be the set of classes reducing into A_p for every $p \mid q$, $\Delta_q = \rho(q)^{-1} \sum_{a \in A_q} \delta_{\{a/q\}}$, $\rho(q) = \prod_{p \mid q} \rho(p)$. Let $w \geq 0$ be a multiplicative function supported on squarefree integers with $w(p) \leq C_0$ ($C_0 \geq 1$) and $w(p) = 0$ unless $\rho(p) \geq 1$, and suppose that for some $\beta, \gamma > 0$ and $t_0 \geq 3$*

$$\sum_{\substack{p \leq t \\ \rho(p) \geq 2}} \frac{w(p)}{p} \geq \beta \log \log t \quad (t \geq t_0), \quad \sum_{p \leq t} \frac{w(p)}{p} \leq \log \log t + \gamma \quad (t \geq 3). \quad (9)$$

Then there are $c = c(\beta) > 0$ and $x_1 = x_1(\beta, \gamma, C_0, t_0)$ such that for $x \geq x_1$

$$\sum_{\substack{q \leq x \\ q \in Q}} w(q) \operatorname{disc}(\Delta_q) \leq x (\log x)^{-c}.$$

One can take $c = \beta(1 - 2^{-1/2})/4$. The constants do not depend on the sets A_p , only on their sizes through (9). (By the second condition, $S_w(x) = \sum_{q \leq x, q \in Q} w(q) \ll_{\gamma, C_0} x$, so the bound is a saving of $(\log x)^{-c}$ over the trivial one whenever w has positive mean value.)

Proof. We follow [3, §§3–4] and indicate the changes. Write $W(h; q) = \rho(q)^{-1} \sum_{a \in A_q} e(ha/q)$ for the normalised Weyl sums. Two facts from [3, Lemma 3.5, Lemma 3.7] hold for every family (A_p) , with no hypothesis on the sets beyond their sizes: (a) for coprime q_1, q_2 , $W(h; q_1 q_2) = W(\bar{q}_1 h; q_2) W(\bar{q}_2 h; q_1)$ with $q_1 \bar{q}_1 \equiv 1 \pmod{q_2}$, $q_2 \bar{q}_2 \equiv 1 \pmod{q_1}$; (b) for $q \in Q$ and $L \geq 2$,

$$\frac{1}{q} \sum_{a \bmod q} \sum_{0 < |h| \leq L} \frac{|W(ah; q)|}{|h|} \ll (\log L) \prod_{p \mid q} \left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{\rho(p)}} + \frac{1}{\sqrt{p}} \right), \quad (10)$$

which is their Lemma 3.7 in dimension one, where the hyperplane constant $\lambda(p)$ equals 1 (a point). Also, by the Erdős–Turán inequality, $\operatorname{disc}(\Delta_q) \ll L^{-1} + \sum_{0 < |h| \leq L} |W(h; q)|/|h|$.

Throughout, $\prod_{p \leq t} (1 + w(p)/p) \leq \exp(\sum_{p \leq t} w(p)/p) \leq e^\gamma \log t$ by (9), and $\sum_{t_1 < p \leq t_2} w(p)/p \leq C_0 \sum_{t_1 < p \leq t_2} 1/p \leq C_0 \log(\log t_2 / \log t_1) + O(C_0)$ by Mertens.

Let $P = \sum_{p \leq x, \rho(p) \geq 2} w(p)(1 - \rho(p)^{-1/2})/p$, so that $\beta(1 - 2^{-1/2}) \log \log x \leq P \leq \log \log x + \gamma$ by (9), and put $z = x^{1/P}$, so that $\log z = \log x/P \geq \log x/(2 \log \log x)$ for $x \geq x_1$. Factor $q = rs$ with s the z -smooth and r the z -rough part; $w(q) = w(r)w(s)$.

Case $s \leq x^{1/3}$. Fix s and L . By (a) and the Erdős–Turán inequality, for r coprime to s , $\text{disc}(\Delta_{rs}) \ll L^{-1} + \sum_{0 < |h| \leq L} |W(\bar{r}h; s)|/|h|$, where we bounded $|W(\bar{s}h; r)| \leq 1$. Group the r by the class $a \equiv \bar{r} \pmod{s}$: then

$$\sum_{\substack{r \leq x/s, rs \in Q \\ p|r \Rightarrow p > z}} w(r) \text{disc}(\Delta_{rs}) \ll \sum_{\substack{a \bmod s \\ (a,s)=1}} \left(\frac{1}{L} + \sum_{0 < |h| \leq L} \frac{|W(ah; s)|}{|h|} \right) \sum_{\substack{r \leq x/s, r \equiv \bar{a} \pmod{s} \\ p|r \Rightarrow p > z}} w(r).$$

This is where the first change occurs. The inner sum is a sum of the non-negative multiplicative function $w \cdot \mathbf{1}_{z\text{-rough}}$ (which is $\leq C_0^{\omega(n)} \ll_\varepsilon n^\varepsilon$) over a progression to the modulus $s \leq x^{1/3} \leq (x/s)^{1/2}$; by Shiu’s theorem [5], uniformly in a ,

$$\sum_{\substack{r \leq x/s, r \equiv \bar{a} \pmod{s} \\ p|r \Rightarrow p > z}} w(r) \ll \frac{x/s}{\varphi(s) \log(x/s)} \exp\left(\sum_{z < p \leq x} \frac{w(p)}{p}\right) \ll \frac{x}{s \varphi(s) \log x} P^{C_0},$$

since $\sum_{z < p \leq x} w(p)/p \leq C_0 \log P + O(C_0)$. Inserting (10),

$$\sum_{\substack{r \leq x/s \\ rs \in Q, r \text{ rough}}} w(r) \text{disc}(\Delta_{rs}) \ll \frac{x P^{C_0}}{\varphi(s) \log x} \left(\frac{1}{L} + (\log L) \prod_{p|s} \left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{\rho(p)}} + \frac{1}{\sqrt{p}} \right) \right).$$

Now multiply by $w(s)$ and sum over z -smooth $s \leq x^{1/3}$, $s \in Q$. Since $w(s)/\varphi(s) = \prod_{p|s} w(p)/(p-1)$,

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_s \frac{w(s)}{\varphi(s)} \prod_{p|s} \left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{\rho(p)}} + \frac{1}{\sqrt{p}} \right) &\leq \prod_{\substack{p \leq z \\ p \in Q}} \left(1 + \frac{w(p)}{p-1} \left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{\rho(p)}} + \frac{1}{\sqrt{p}} \right) \right) \\ &\ll \prod_{\substack{p \leq z \\ p \in Q}} \left(1 + \frac{w(p)}{p} \right) \exp\left(- \sum_{\substack{p \leq z \\ \rho(p) \geq 2}} \frac{w(p)}{p} \left(1 - \frac{1}{\sqrt{\rho(p)}} \right) \right), \end{aligned}$$

because $(1 + w(1/\sqrt{p} + p^{-1/2})/(p-1))/(1 + w/p) \leq \exp(-w(1 - 1/\sqrt{p})/p + O(C_0 p^{-3/2}))$ and the primes with $\rho(p) = 1$ contribute $O(1)$; the exponential is $\exp(-P_z)$ with P_z the sum defining P cut at z , and $P - P_z = \sum_{z < p \leq x} (\dots) \leq C_0 \log P + O(C_0)$, so $\exp(-P_z) \ll P^{C_0} e^{-P}$. Similarly $\sum_s w(s)/\varphi(s) \ll \prod_{p \leq z, p \in Q} (1 + w(p)/p)$. With $L = e^P$ the case contributes

$$\ll \frac{x}{\log x} \prod_{\substack{p \leq z \\ p \in Q}} \left(1 + \frac{w(p)}{p} \right) \cdot P^{2C_0+1} e^{-P} \ll x P^{2C_0+1} e^{-P},$$

using $\prod_{p \leq z} (1 + w(p)/p) \leq e^\gamma \log z \leq e^\gamma \log x$.

Case $s > x^{1/3}$. Here we use $\text{disc} \leq 1$ and bound the weighted number of $q \leq x$ in Q whose z -smooth part exceeds $x^{1/3}$. For $X \geq 1$ let $\mathcal{R}(X) = \sum_{r \leq X, p|r \Rightarrow p > z} w(r)$. If $X < z$ then $\mathcal{R}(X) = 1$. If $X \geq z$, the upper bound of Halberstam and Richert for non-negative multiplicative functions [6, Theorem III.3.5] gives $\mathcal{R}(X) \ll_{C_0} (X/\log X) \prod_{z < p \leq X} (1 + w(p)/p) \ll (X/\log z) P^{C_0} = X P^{C_0+1}/\log x$. In both cases $\mathcal{R}(X) \leq 1 + O(X P^{C_0+1}/\log x)$, and for $X = x/s \geq 1$ this is $\leq 2x/s$ once $x \geq x_1$. Hence

$$\sum_{\substack{q \leq x, q \in Q \\ s > x^{1/3}}} w(q) \leq \sum_{\substack{x^{1/3} < s \leq x \\ P^+(s) \leq z}} w(s) \mathcal{R}(x/s) \leq 2x \sum_{\substack{s > x^{1/3} \\ P^+(s) \leq z}} \frac{w(s)}{s}.$$

Apply Lemma 3 with $X = x^{1/3}$, so $u = \log X / \log z = P/3$; the conditions $z \geq z_0$ and $u_0 \leq u \leq \log z$ hold for $x \geq x_1(\beta, \gamma, C_0, t_0)$, because $P \rightarrow \infty$ and $P/3 \leq \log \log x \leq \log z$. The sum is therefore $\leq e^\gamma \log z \cdot \exp(-\frac{1}{6}P \log(P/3))$, and since $\log z \leq \log x = e^{\log \log x} \leq e^{P/(\beta(1-2^{-1/2}))}$,

$$\sum_{\substack{q \leq x, q \in Q \\ s > x^{1/3}}} w(q) \ll_\gamma x \exp\left(\frac{P}{\beta(1-2^{-1/2})} - \frac{P \log(P/3)}{6}\right) \leq x e^{-P}$$

as soon as $\log(P/3) \geq 6(1 + 1/(\beta(1-2^{-1/2})))$, which again holds for $x \geq x_1$. This is the second change: the Dickman-type decay of Lemma 3, with $u \asymp \log \log x$, beats every fixed power of $\log x$, so no analogue of the counting argument of [3, Lemma 3.2] is needed.

Conclusion. Adding the two cases, $\sum_{q \leq x, q \in Q} w(q) \text{disc}(\Delta_q) \ll_{\gamma, C_0} x P^{2C_0+1} e^{-P}$, and since $P \geq \beta(1-2^{-1/2}) \log \log x$, this is $\leq x(\log x)^{-c}$ with $c = \beta(1-2^{-1/2})/4$ for $x \geq x_1$. $\square$

In words. Kowalski and Soundararajan's theorem says that a set defined prime by prime through the Chinese remainder theorem is equidistributed modulo most q , at a rate governed only by how many primes carry at least two residues; the proof averages the rough part of the modulus over residue classes modulo the smooth part, and the local sets enter only through their sizes. Multiplicative weights of bounded mean ride along: Shiu's theorem replaces the sieve count, Rankin's trick with Dickman decay disposes of the moduli with a large smooth part, and the rest is bookkeeping in Euler products.

Remark 5. For $w = \lambda\omega$ and the split primes of a quadratic f : $w(p) = 2p/(p-4) \in [2, 10]$ for split $p \geq 5$, $w(p) = 0$ at inert primes and at the finitely many primes dividing $2D$, $\rho(p) = 2$ at split primes, and (9) holds with $\beta = 1 - o(1)$ and some $\gamma = \gamma(f)$ by the prime number theorem for the character χ_D ($\sum_{p \leq t} \text{split } 1/p = \frac{1}{2} \log \log t + O_D(1)$). Removing in addition the primes dividing a squarefree u (where $R_p^{(u)} = \emptyset$) lowers the first sum in (9) by at most $C_0 \sum_{p|u} 1/p \leq C_0(\log \log \log u + O(1))$ and can only lower the second; so (9) holds with $\beta = \frac{1}{2}$, the same γ , and $t_0 = \exp((\log \log u)^A)$ for an absolute $A = A(C_0)$, $A \leq 3$ for $C_0 \leq 10$: in particular uniformly for $t \geq \exp((\log \log u)^3)$, $u \geq u_1$. The resulting exponent is $c = (1-2^{-1/2})/8 \approx 0.037$; no attempt has been made to optimise it, and none is needed for the Cesàro form.

Theorem 6 (small moduli, unconditional). *For every irreducible quadratic f there is $c = c(f) > 0$ such that, uniformly for squarefree u with $\omega(u) \geq 1$ and $Y \geq \max(\exp((\log \log u)^3), Y_1(f))$,*

$$\mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(Y) = \sum_{d' \leq Y} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \sum_{x \in R_{d'}^{(u)}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) \ll_f Y(\log Y)^{-c}.$$

Consequently, for every fixed $\varepsilon > 0$, $\sum_{u \leq H^{1-\varepsilon}} w(u) \mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(H/u) \ll_{f, \varepsilon} H(\log H)^{1-c}$: the small-moduli part of the pieces with $u \leq H^{1-\varepsilon}$ is $o(H \log H)$ unconditionally (the pieces with $u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$ are treated in full in Theorem 12).

Proof. By (8), $|\mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(Y)| \leq \frac{3}{2} \sum_{d' \leq Y} \lambda(d') \omega(d') \text{disc}(\Delta_{d'}^{(u)})$, the sum over squarefree split d' coprime to u . Apply Proposition 4 to the family $A_p = R_p^{(u)}$ (of size 2 at split $p \nmid 2Du$, empty otherwise) and to $w = |\lambda\omega| \cdot \mathbf{1}_{(\cdot, 2Du)=1}$ (which is non-negative, multiplicative, and bounded by 10 at every prime, $|\lambda\omega(3)| = 6$); by Remark 5 the hypotheses hold with constants depending only on f provided $Y \geq \exp((\log \log u)^3)$ and $u \geq u_1$, and for the finitely many $u < u_1$ they hold with $t_0 = t_0(f)$. Since Q is then exactly the set of admissible d' and $\rho(d') = \omega(d')$, the bound is $\ll Y(\log Y)^{-c}$ with $c = c(f)$. For the consequence, the weight $w(u)$ has $\sum_{u \leq U} w(u)/u \ll \log U$, and for $u \leq H^{1-\varepsilon}$ we have $\log(H/u) \geq \varepsilon \log H$, so $\sum_{u \leq H^{1-\varepsilon}} w(u) (H/u)(\log(H/u))^{-c} \ll_\varepsilon H(\log H)^{-c} \sum_{u \leq H} w(u)/u \ll H(\log H)^{1-c}$. $\square$

In words. For moduli shorter than the length there is no short-interval problem, only the question whether the dilated roots are spread out modulo d' ; and spreading out is a consequence of the Chinese remainder theorem alone, as Kowalski and Soundararajan showed, at a rate that does not see which two-point sets sit at the primes. So this half of every piece is unconditional, and the loss against the trivial bound is a power of log, which is exactly what the Cesàro form can afford.

3.3 Large moduli: the far moduli are trivial

For $d' > Y$ and $m \in [1, d']$ at most one $h \leq Y$ lies in the class of m , so $B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m) = (Y - m)^+ - Y^2/(2d')$ and

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{d' > Z} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \sum_{x \in R'_{d'}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) &= \sum_{x \leq Y} (Y - x) \sum_{\substack{d' > Z \\ d' | Q_u(x)}} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} - \frac{Y^2}{2} \sum_{d' > Z} \frac{\lambda(d') \rho(d')}{d'^2} \\ &=: \mathcal{A}_Z - \mathcal{E}_Z \quad (Z \geq Y), \end{aligned} \quad (11)$$

where d' ranges over squarefree split moduli coprime to u , and we used that an integer $x \in [1, Y]$ is the representative of an element of $R'_{d'}$ exactly when $d' \mid Q_u(x)$. Both terms are of the same size, and the question is how well they cancel. The next lemma says that for $Z = u^2 Y$ there is nothing to cancel: both terms are already small.

Lemma 7 (far moduli). *Let u be squarefree with $\omega(u) \geq 1$, $Y \geq 4|D| + 4$ and $L \geq 1$. Then*

$$\mathcal{P}_u^{\text{far}}(Y; L) := \sum_{d' > u^2 Y L} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \sum_{x \in R'_{d'}^{(u)}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) \ll_f \frac{Y}{u^2 L},$$

uniformly in u and L . Consequently $\sum_{u \geq 1} w(u) |\mathcal{P}_u^{\text{far}}(H/u; L)| \ll_f H/L$.

Proof. Put $Z = u^2 Y L$. Since $\lambda \rho$ has mean value $\ll 1$ (Proposition 1), $\sum_{d' > Z} \lambda \rho(d')/d'^2 \ll 1/Z$ and $\mathcal{E}_Z \ll Y^2/Z = Y/(u^2 L)$.

For $\mathcal{A}_Z$ write $\lambda = 1 * \kappa$ with κ multiplicative, supported on squarefree split integers, $\kappa(p) = \lambda(p) - 1 = 4/(p-4) \geq 0$. Dropping the conditions on the moduli (all terms are non-negative) and substituting $d' = ge \dots$ more precisely writing $d' = g d''$ with $g \mid d'$ carrying κ , and $d'' = n/(ge)$ with $n = Q_u(x)$, so that $1/d'' = ge/n$ and $d'' > Z/g$ becomes $e < n/(gZ)$,

$$\sum_{\substack{d' > Z \\ d' \mid n}} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \leq \sum_{g \mid n} \kappa(g) \sum_{\substack{e \mid n/g \\ e < n/(gZ)}} \frac{e}{n}, \quad \text{hence} \quad \mathcal{A}_Z \leq \sum_g \kappa(g) \sum_e e \sum_{\substack{x \leq Y, \\ ge \mid Q_u(x) \\ Q_u(x) > geZ}} \frac{Y - x}{Q_u(x)}.$$

In the inner sum $Q_u(x) > ge u^2 Y L$ and $Q_u(x) \leq u^2 Y^2 + |D| \leq 2u^2 Y^2$, so $ge < 2Y/L$; moreover $u^2 x^2 = Q_u(x) + D > ge u^2 Y L - |D| \geq ge u^2 Y L/2$ because $Y \geq 2|D|$, so $x > x_0 := \sqrt{ge Y L/2}$, and then $u^2 x^2 \geq 2|D|$ gives $Q_u(x) \geq u^2 x^2/2$. Therefore

$$\frac{Y - x}{Q_u(x)} \leq \min\left(\frac{1}{ge u^2}, \frac{2Y}{u^2 x^2}\right).$$

The x with $ge \mid Q_u(x)$ lie in $\rho_u(ge)$ residue classes modulo ge , where $\rho_u(m)$ denotes the number of roots of Q_u modulo m (for all m , not only squarefree split ones). In one class, the first term beyond x_0 contributes at most $2Y/(u^2 x_0^2) = 4/(ge u^2 L)$ and the others at most $(ge)^{-1} \int_{x_0}^{\infty} 2Y dx/(u^2 x^2) = 2\sqrt{2} \sqrt{Y/(ge L)}/(ge u^2)$; so

$$\mathcal{A}_Z \leq \frac{1}{u^2} \sum_g \frac{\kappa(g)}{g} \sum_{e < 2Y/(gL)} \rho_u(ge) \left(\frac{4}{L} + 3\sqrt{\frac{Y}{ge L}} \right).$$

Now ρ_u is multiplicative; $\rho_u(p^k) = 1 + \chi_D(p) \leq 2$ for $p \nmid 2Du$; $\rho_u(p^k) = 0$ for $p \mid u$, $p \nmid D$; and for the finitely many $p \mid 2D$, $\rho_u(p^k) \leq 4p^{v_p(D)}$ uniformly in k and in squarefree u : if $k \leq v_p(D)$ this is trivial, and if $k > v_p(D) =: v$ a solution forces $v_p(u^2 x^2) = v$, so $x = p^a x'$ with $a = v/2 - v_p(u)$ fixed and x' a unit with $x'^2 \equiv D/(p^v u'^2) \pmod{p^{k-v}}$ ($u = p^{v_p(u)} u'$), a congruence with at most 4 solutions modulo p^{k-v} , each giving $p^{v-a} \leq p^v$ classes of x modulo p^k . Hence $\rho_u \leq \rho^*$ pointwise, where ρ^* is the multiplicative function with $\rho^*(p^k) = 1 + \chi_D(p)$ for $p \nmid 2D$ and $4p^{v_p(D)}$ for $p \mid 2D$, which does not depend on u ; $\rho_u(ge) \leq \rho_u(g)\rho_u(e)$ for squarefree split g (at a prime $p \mid g$, $\rho_u(p^{1+j}) = 2 \leq 2\rho_u(p^j)$); and $\sum_{e \leq t} \rho^*(e) \ll_f t$ (the Dirichlet series of ρ^* is $\zeta(s)L(s, \chi_D)$ times a product absolutely convergent for $\Re s > \frac{1}{2}$), whence $\sum_{e \leq t} \rho_u(e)e^{-1/2} \ll_f t^{1/2}$ by partial summation. With $t = 2Y/(gL)$ the inner sum is therefore $\ll \rho_u(g)(Y/(gL^2) + Y/(gL)) \ll \rho_u(g)Y/(gL)$, and $\mathcal{A}_Z \ll (Y/(u^2 L)) \sum_g \kappa(g)\rho_u(g)/g^2 \ll Y/(u^2 L)$.

For the consequence,

$$\sum_{u \geq 1} w(u) \frac{H}{u} u^{-2} L^{-1} = \frac{H}{L} \sum_u w(u) u^{-3} \ll \frac{H}{L}, \quad \text{as } \sum_{u \leq t} w(u) \ll t.$$

□

In words. When the modulus exceeds u^2 times the length, each root that falls below the length has a complementary divisor $e = Q_u(x)/d'$ below the length, and the weights $1/d' = e/Q_u(x)$ decay like $1/x^2$; counting crudely, the whole range beyond $u^2 YL$ weighs only $Y/(u^2 L)$, which is summable over u and small for $L \rightarrow \infty$. So the far moduli are negligible for trivial reasons, at the price of extending the window to $u^2 YL$; no reflection argument is needed. The trivial bound also fixes the scale of everything else: the small moduli $d' \leq Y$ and the window $Y < d' \leq u^2 YL$ each have trivial size $O(Y)$, the far moduli $Y/(u^2 L)$.

4 The first piece and the large pieces

4.1 $u = 1$: the theorem of Duke, Friedlander and Iwaniec

Lemma 8 (sharp cut-offs from smooth ones). *Let D be a fundamental discriminant for which Theorem 1.1 of [1] holds (positive odd D as stated there; negative D by their §16), and let $q \geq 1$, $k \geq 1$. Then for $t \geq 2$,*

$$\sum_{\substack{d \leq t \\ q \mid d}} \sum_{r \in R_d} e\left(\frac{kr}{d}\right) \ll_{D, \varepsilon} k^{1/4} t^{11/12 + \varepsilon},$$

uniformly in q ; the same holds with the additional factor $\lambda(d)$, and with d restricted to squarefree split moduli.

Proof. Theorem 1.1 of [1] states: for f smooth, supported on $[V, 2V]$, with $|f| \leq 1$ and $y^2 |f''(y)| \leq 1$, $\sum_{c \equiv 0(q)} f(c) \sum_{b^2 \equiv D(c)} e(hb/c) \ll h^{1/4} (V + h\sqrt{D})^{3/4} D^{1/8 - 1/1331}$ with an absolute implied constant. The statement is linear in f ; hence if f satisfies $|f| \leq \Delta^2$, $y^2 |f''| \leq \Delta^2$, the bound holds with an extra factor Δ^2 (apply it to f/Δ^2). Let $\Delta = t^{1/12}$ and let χ_t be a smooth function equal to 1 on $[0, t(1 - 1/\Delta)]$, to 0 on $[t, \infty)$, with $|\chi_t^{(j)}| \ll (\Delta/t)^j$. Decompose $\chi_t = \sum_V \chi_t \psi_V$ with a smooth dyadic partition of unity $\{\psi_V\}$ on $[1, \infty)$: each piece is supported on $[V, 2V]$ with $y^2 |(\chi_t \psi_V)''| \ll 1$ except the piece containing the edge, for which $y^2 | \cdot'' | \ll \Delta^2$. Summing the DFI bound over the dyadic $V \leq t$ gives $\ll \Delta^2 k^{1/4} t^{3/4 + \varepsilon}$ for fixed D . The difference between the sharp cut-off and χ_t is supported on $(t(1 - 1/\Delta), t]$ and is bounded, for the moduli $q \mid d$ there, by $\sum_{d \in (t(1-1/\Delta), t], q \mid d} \omega(d) \ll (t/(q\Delta) + 1) t^\varepsilon$ by Shiu's theorem for the multiplicative function ω on short intervals of progressions ($t/\Delta \geq t^\varepsilon$). Altogether

$\ll t^{1/6} k^{1/4} t^{3/4+\varepsilon} + t^{11/12+\varepsilon} \ll k^{1/4} t^{11/12+\varepsilon}$. The weight $\lambda(d) = \sum_{g|d} \kappa(g)$ is removed by writing $\sum_d \lambda(d) F(d) = \sum_g \kappa(g) \sum_{g|d} F(d)$, applying the bound with q replaced by $\text{lcm}(q, g)$, and using $\sum_g \kappa(g) < \infty$; the restriction to squarefree split d is a further Möbius inversion (over $\ell^2 \mid d$ and over the inert and special primes, which carry no roots or a single root and are removed by inclusion–exclusion at the cost of the divisor bound). $\square$

Theorem 9 (the first piece: small moduli). *For D as in Lemma 8,*

$$\mathcal{P}_1^{\leq}(Y) = \sum_{d' \leq Y} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \sum_{x \in R_{d'}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) \ll_{D, \varepsilon} Y^{12/13+\varepsilon}.$$

Together with Lemma 7 ($u = 1$, $L = Y^\varepsilon$; the window $(Y, YL]$ is then the only part not covered) this gives $\mathcal{P}_1(Y) = \mathcal{W}_1(Y; Y^\varepsilon) + O(Y^{1-\varepsilon})$, and Proposition 18 with $(\theta, B) = (\frac{11}{12}, \frac{1}{4})$ bounds the window by $Y^{11/12+O(\varepsilon)}$: so $\mathcal{P}_1(Y) \ll Y^{1-\delta}$ unconditionally.

Proof. Lemma 8 gives (7) for $u = 1$ with $\theta = \frac{11}{12} + \varepsilon$, $B = \frac{1}{4}$. By Lemma 2, $T_k(Y) \ll k^{1/4} (kY)^{12/13+\varepsilon}$, and inserting into (6): $\sum_{k \leq K} k^{-2} T_k \ll Y^{12/13+\varepsilon} \sum_{k \leq K} k^{-2+1/4+12/13} \ll Y^{12/13+\varepsilon} K^{0.18}$, while $\sum_{k > K} k^{-2} |T_k| \ll Y/K$; with $K = Y^{1/20}$ both are $\ll Y^{12/13+\varepsilon}$. $\square$

4.2 Large u : averaging the dilations

Throughout this subsection g is the multiplicative function of the set-up ($g(p) = \lambda(p)\omega(p)$ for odd p , supported on squarefree integers; $g(p) \leq 10$ at every prime), $\chi = \chi_D$ is the Kronecker symbol, and m, m_d are the constants

$$m = L(1, \chi) \prod_p \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right) \left(1 - \frac{\chi(p)}{p}\right) \left(1 + \frac{g(p)}{p}\right), \quad m_d = m \prod_{p|d} \left(1 + \frac{g(p)}{p}\right)^{-1}, \quad (12)$$

$$M_d = \begin{cases} c_f m_d & (\omega(2) \neq 1), \\ c_f m_d / 2 & (\omega(2) = 1), \end{cases}$$

the product converging absolutely since $g(p) - 1 - \chi(p) = (1 + \chi(p))\kappa(p) \ll 1/p$ for $p \nmid 2D$ (at the finitely many $p \mid 2D$ the factor is merely bounded); in the case $\omega(2) = 1$ the product is taken with $g(2) = 0$, and the factor $\frac{1}{2}$ accounts for the shift $u = 2u'$. M_d is the mean value of w on the integers coprime to d (d odd).

Lemma 10 ($\lambda\omega$ in progressions and against characters). *For $U \geq 2$ and $d \geq 1$ coprime to $2D$ (the sums over squarefree n):*

$$(i) \quad \sum_{\substack{n \leq U \\ (n, d)=1}} g(n) = m_d U + O_{D, \varepsilon}(U^{1/2+\varepsilon} d^\varepsilon);$$

$$(ii) \quad \text{for every non-principal character } \psi \text{ modulo } d, \quad \sum_{n \leq U} g(n) \psi(n) \ll_{D, \varepsilon} U^{1/2+\varepsilon} d^{1/2};$$

$$(iii) \quad \text{for every } b \text{ coprime to } d, \quad \sum_{\substack{n \leq U \\ n \equiv b \pmod{d}}} g(n) = \frac{1}{\varphi(d)} \sum_{\substack{n \leq U \\ (n, d)=1}} g(n) + O_{D, \varepsilon}(U^{1/2+\varepsilon} d^{1/2}).$$

Proof. (ii) The Dirichlet series of $g\psi$ is $\prod_p (1 + g(p)\psi(p)p^{-s}) = L(s, \psi)L(s, \chi\psi)G_\psi(s)$ with $G_\psi(s) = \prod_p (1 + g(p)\psi(p)p^{-s})(1 - \psi(p)p^{-s})(1 - \chi\psi(p)p^{-s})$, an Euler product of the form $\prod_{p \nmid 2D} (1 + O(p^{-s-1}) + O(p^{-2s}))$ times finitely many bounded factors, absolutely convergent

for $\Re s > \frac{1}{2}$ uniformly in ψ ; write γ_ψ for its coefficients, so that $\sum_n |\gamma_\psi(n)| n^{-1/2-\varepsilon} \ll_\varepsilon 1$. Then $g\psi = \psi * \chi\psi * \gamma_\psi$ and

$$\sum_{n \leq U} g(n)\psi(n) = \sum_{n_3} \gamma_\psi(n_3) \sum_{n_1 n_2 \leq U/n_3} \psi(n_1) \chi\psi(n_2).$$

Both ψ and $\chi\psi$ are non-principal characters (to the moduli d and $d|D|$; $\chi\psi$ is non-principal because χ is primitive of conductor $|D|$ coprime to d), so by the Pólya–Vinogradov inequality their partial sums are $\ll (d|D|)^{1/2} \log(d|D|)$, and Dirichlet’s hyperbola method gives $\sum_{n_1 n_2 \leq X} \psi(n_1) \chi\psi(n_2) \ll X^{1/2} d^{1/2} \log(d|D|)$. Summing over n_3 with the weights $|\gamma_\psi(n_3)|(U/n_3)^{1/2}$ gives (ii).

(i) Likewise $\sum_{(n,d)=1} g(n)n^{-s} = \zeta(s)L(s,\chi)G_d(s)$ with $G_d(s) = \prod_p (1 + g(p)\mathbf{1}_{p \nmid d} p^{-s})(1 - p^{-s})(1 - \chi(p)p^{-s})$, whose coefficients γ_d satisfy $\sum_n |\gamma_d(n)| n^{-1/2-\varepsilon} \ll d^\varepsilon$ (the factors at $p \mid d$ are $(1 - p^{-s})(1 - \chi(p)p^{-s})$). Since $\sum_{n_1 n_2 \leq X} \chi(n_2) = L(1, \chi)X + O(X^{1/2})$ by the hyperbola method, $\sum_{n \leq U, (n,d)=1} g(n) = \sum_{n_3} \gamma_d(n_3) (L(1, \chi)U/n_3 + O((U/n_3)^{1/2})) = L(1, \chi)G_d(1)U + O(U^{1/2+\varepsilon} d^\varepsilon)$, and $L(1, \chi)G_d(1) = m_d$. (iii) follows from (i) and (ii) by orthogonality of characters. $\square$

In words. The number of roots of f modulo n is a divisor-type function twisted by a character, and such functions are equidistributed in progressions to moduli well below U ; the proof is Dirichlet’s hyperbola method with the Pólya–Vinogradov inequality. No deep input is used.

The dilation average. For squarefree split $d' > 1$, a unit a modulo d' and $Y > 0$ put

$$G_{d'}(a, Y) = \sum_{r \in R_{d'}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle ar \rangle_{d'}), \quad \bar{G}_{d'}(Y) = \frac{1}{\varphi(d')} \sum_{a \in (\mathbb{Z}/d')^\times} G_{d'}(a, Y), \quad (13)$$

so that the inner sum in the piece (4) is $G_{d'}(\bar{u}, Y)$ (by (3) and the symmetry of $R_{d'}$).

Lemma 11 (the dilation average). *With $\phi(\theta) = \theta - \theta^2$,*

$$\bar{G}_{d'}(Y) = \frac{\omega(d')}{2\varphi(d')} \sum_{e \mid d'} \mu(e) e \phi\left(\left\{\frac{Y}{e}\right\}\right). \quad (14)$$

Consequently: (a) $|\bar{G}_{d'}(Y)| \leq \omega(d')\sigma(d')/(8\varphi(d'))$ and $|\bar{G}_{d'}(Y)| \leq \omega(d')\tau(d')Y/(2\varphi(d'))$ for all $Y > 0$; (b) $\bar{G}_{d'}(Y) = -\omega(d')Y^2/(2d') = G_{d'}(a, Y)$ for $0 < Y < 1$ and every a ; (c) $Y \mapsto G_{d'}(a, Y)$ and $Y \mapsto \bar{G}_{d'}(Y)$ are continuous, piecewise linear, with $|\partial_Y| \leq \omega(d')$; (d) $|G_{d'}(a, Y)| \leq \omega(d') \min(d', Y)$ for all a, Y ; (e)

$$\int_0^\infty \bar{G}_{d'}(Y) \frac{dY}{Y^2} = \begin{cases} -\frac{\omega(p) \log p}{2\varphi(p)} = -\frac{\log p}{p-1} & \text{if } d' = p \text{ is prime,} \\ 0 & \text{if } d' \text{ has at least two prime factors,} \end{cases}$$

the integral converging absolutely.

Proof. Every $r \in R_{d'}$ is a unit ($r^2 \equiv D$, $(D, d') = 1$), so $a \mapsto ar$ permutes the units and $\sum_a G_{d'}(a, Y) = \omega(d') \sum_{x \in (\mathbb{Z}/d')^\times} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(x)$. By Möbius inversion and the elementary identity $\sum_{h' \leq X} (X - h') = X^2/2 - X/2 + \phi(\{X\})/2$ ($X \geq 0$),

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{x \in (\mathbb{Z}/d')^\times} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(x) &= \sum_{e \mid d'} \mu(e) e \sum_{h' \leq Y/e} \left(\frac{Y}{e} - h'\right) - \frac{\varphi(d')Y^2}{2d'} \\ &= \frac{Y^2}{2} \sum_{e \mid d'} \frac{\mu(e)}{e} - \frac{Y}{2} \sum_{e \mid d'} \mu(e) + \frac{1}{2} \sum_{e \mid d'} \mu(e) e \phi\left(\left\{\frac{Y}{e}\right\}\right) - \frac{\varphi(d')Y^2}{2d'}, \end{aligned}$$

and the first, second and last terms cancel ($d' > 1$). This is (14). (a): $0 \leq e\phi(\{Y/e\}) \leq e/4$ gives the first bound; for $e \leq Y$ also $e\phi \leq Y/4$, and for $e > Y$, $e\phi(Y/e) = Y - Y^2/e \in [0, Y]$, giving the second. (b): for $Y < 1$ all $e > Y$, so the sum is $Y \sum \mu(e) - Y^2 \sum \mu(e)/e = -Y^2 \varphi(d')/d'$; and no root has representative $\leq Y < 1$, so $G_{d'}(a, Y) = -\omega(d')Y^2/(2d')$ directly. (c): $\partial_Y B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m) = \#\{h \leq Y : h \equiv m\} - Y/d' \in (-1, 1)$ away from the integers. (d): from the proof of Proposition 1 for $d' \leq Y$ (symmetric pairs contribute $\leq d'/4$ each); for $d' > Y$, $B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m) + B_{d'}^{(Y)}(d' - m) = (Y - m)^+ + (Y - d' + m)^+ - Y^2/d' \in [-Y, Y]$. (e): put $K(\tau) = \int_\tau^\infty \phi(\{v\})v^{-2}dv$, so that for $0 < T < 1$, $\int_T^\infty \bar{G}_{d'}(Y)Y^{-2}dY = \frac{\omega}{2\varphi} \sum_{e|d'} \mu(e)K(T/e)$, and for $\tau < 1$, $K(\tau) = \int_\tau^1 (v^{-1} - 1)dv + K(1) = -\log \tau - 1 + \tau + K(1)$. Hence $\sum_{e|d'} \mu(e)K(T/e) = \sum_{e|d'} \mu(e) \log e + T\varphi(d')/d'$, because $\sum_{e|d'} \mu(e) = 0$; letting $T \rightarrow 0$ (absolute convergence at 0 follows from (b)) gives $\frac{\omega}{2\varphi} \sum_{e|d'} \mu(e) \log e$, and for $d' = p_1 \cdots p_k$, $\sum_{e|d'} \mu(e) \log e = -\sum_i \log p_i \sum_{e'|d'/p_i} \mu(e')$ is $-\log d'$ if $k = 1$ and 0 if $k \geq 2$. $\square$

Theorem 12 (Type II range). *For every $\varepsilon \in (0, \frac{1}{10})$ there is $\delta = \delta(\varepsilon) > 0$ such that*

$$\sum_{u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}} w(u) \mathcal{P}_u(H/u) = c_{\text{off}}(f) H + O_{f,\varepsilon}(H^{1-\delta}),$$

the sum over all squarefree $u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$ with $\omega(u) \geq 1$, including $u > H$, where

$$c_{\text{off}}(f) = \sum_{d'} \frac{\lambda(d')M_{d'}}{d'} \int_0^\infty \bar{G}_{d'}(Y) \frac{dY}{Y^2} = - \sum_{\substack{p \text{ split} \\ p|2D}} \frac{\lambda(p)M_p \log p}{p(p-1)} < 0, \quad (15)$$

with $M_p = c_f m_p$ as in (12); both series converge absolutely.

Proof. Write $U_0 = H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$, $Y_0 = H/U_0 = H^{1/3-\varepsilon}$, $\eta = \varepsilon/2$, and let $\varepsilon' = \varepsilon/12$ be the exponent in Lemma 10. All implied constants depend on f and ε .

Step 1: $u > H$. Here $Y = H/u < 1$ and $\mathcal{P}_u(Y) = \sum_{(d',u)=1} (\lambda(d')/d') \bar{G}_{d'}(Y)$ exactly, by Lemma 11(b).

Step 2: dyadic blocks. For $U \in [U_0, H)$ of the form $U_0 2^j$ consider the $u \in (U, 2U]$, $u \leq H$, and put $Y_U = H/U \in (1, Y_0]$ and $Z_U = Y_U H^\eta$; for u in the block, $H/u \in [Y_U/2, Y_U]$.

Step 3: moduli $d' > Z_U$ in a block. For $d' > Z_U \geq Y$, $G_{d'}(\bar{u}, Y) = \sum_{x \leq Y, d'|Q_u(x)} (Y - x) - \omega(d')Y^2/(2d')$ as in (11). Since $\lambda(d') \ll d'^{\varepsilon'}$ and $\tau(n) \ll n^{\varepsilon'}$, for $n = Q_u(x) \leq 2H^2$ we have $\sum_{d' > Z, d'|n} \lambda(d')/d' \ll H^{3\varepsilon'}/Z$, so that $\sum_{d' > Z_U} (\lambda(d')/d') |G_{d'}(\bar{u}, H/u)| \ll Y_U^2 H^{3\varepsilon'}/Z_U$; and by Lemma 11(a), $\sum_{d' > Z_U} (\lambda(d')/d') |\bar{G}_{d'}(H/u)| \ll Y_U \sum_{d' > Z_U} \lambda \omega \tau(d')/(d' \varphi(d')) \ll Y_U Z_U^{-1+\varepsilon'}$. Summing either bound over the block with $\sum_{u \leq 2U} w(u) \ll U$ gives $\ll U Y_U^2 H^{3\varepsilon'}/Z_U = H^{1-\eta+3\varepsilon'}$.

Step 4: moduli $d' \leq Z_U$ in a block: the averaging. Fix such a d' and put $G^\circ(a, Y) = G_{d'}(a, Y) - \bar{G}_{d'}(Y)$, a function on $(\mathbb{Z}/d')^\times$ with mean zero, so that $G^\circ(a, Y) = \sum_{\psi \neq \psi_0} \hat{G}(\psi, Y) \psi(a)$ with $\hat{G}(\psi, Y) = \varphi(d')^{-1} \sum_a G^\circ(a, Y) \bar{\psi}(a)$, the sum over non-principal characters modulo d' . Since $\psi(\bar{u}) = \bar{\psi}(u)$,

$$\mathcal{E}_{d'}(U) := \sum_{\substack{U < u \leq 2U \\ (u, d')=1}} w(u) G^\circ\left(\bar{u}, \frac{H}{u}\right) = \sum_{\psi \neq \psi_0} \sum_{U < u \leq 2U} w(u) \bar{\psi}(u) \hat{G}\left(\psi, \frac{H}{u}\right).$$

For fixed ψ , partial summation against $S_\psi(t) = \sum_{U < u \leq t} w(u) \bar{\psi}(u) \ll U^{1/2+\varepsilon'} d'^{1/2}$ (Lemma 10(ii)) gives

$$\left| \sum_u w(u) \bar{\psi}(u) \hat{G}(\psi, H/u) \right| \leq \sup_t |S_\psi(t)| \left(\sup_u |\hat{G}(\psi, H/u)| + \text{Var}_{u \in (U, 2U]} \hat{G}(\psi, H/u) \right).$$

Now sum over ψ using Cauchy–Schwarz and Parseval on $(\mathbb{Z}/d')^\times$:

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{\psi} |\hat{G}(\psi, Y)| &\leq \varphi(d')^{1/2} \left(\sum_{\psi} |\hat{G}(\psi, Y)|^2 \right)^{1/2} \\ &= \left(\sum_a |G^\circ(a, Y)|^2 \right)^{1/2} \leq \varphi(d')^{1/2} \max_a |G^\circ(a, Y)| \\ &\leq 2\varphi(d')^{1/2} \omega(d') \min(d', Y) \end{aligned}$$

by Lemma 11(d), and in the same way, using (c) and $\partial_u = -(H/u^2)\partial_Y$,

$$\sum_{\psi} \text{Var}_u \hat{G}(\psi, H/u) \leq \int_U^{2U} \varphi(d')^{1/2} \max_a |\partial_u G^\circ(a, H/u)| du \leq 2\varphi(d')^{1/2} \omega(d') Y_U.$$

Hence $|\mathcal{E}_{d'}(U)| \ll U^{1/2+\varepsilon'} d'^{1/2} \varphi(d')^{1/2} \omega(d') Y_U$, and

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{d' \leq Z_U} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} |\mathcal{E}_{d'}(U)| &\ll U^{1/2+\varepsilon'} Y_U Z_U^{1+\varepsilon'} \ll H^{1/2+\varepsilon'} Y_U^{3/2} H^{\eta+2\varepsilon'} \\ &\leq H^{1/2+\eta+3\varepsilon'+(3/2)(1/3-\varepsilon)} = H^{1-3\varepsilon/4} \leq H^{1-\varepsilon/4}, \end{aligned}$$

using $U = H/Y_U$, $Y_U \leq Y_0 = H^{1/3-\varepsilon}$, $\eta = \varepsilon/2$ and $\varepsilon' = \varepsilon/12$. Together with Step 3 (where $\eta - 3\varepsilon' = \varepsilon/4$) and the $O(\log H)$ blocks,

$$\sum_{u > U_0} w(u) \mathcal{P}_u(H/u) = \mathcal{M}(H) + O(H^{1-\varepsilon/4} \log H), \quad (16)$$

$$\mathcal{M}(H) := \sum_{d'} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \sum_{\substack{u > U_0 \\ (u, d')=1}} w(u) \bar{G}_{d'}\left(\frac{H}{u}\right),$$

where the double series converges absolutely: for $u \leq H$, Lemma 11(a) gives

$$\sum_{d'} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} |\bar{G}_{d'}(Y)| \ll \sum_{d' \leq Y} \frac{\lambda \omega \sigma}{d' \varphi}(d') + Y \sum_{d' > Y} \frac{\lambda \omega \tau}{d' \varphi}(d') \ll Y^{\varepsilon'},$$

for $u > H$ it gives $\ll Y^2$, and $\sum_{U_0 < u \leq H} w(u)(H/u)^{\varepsilon'} + \sum_{u > H} w(u)(H/u)^2 < \infty$.

Step 5: the main term. For each d' let $A_{d'}(t) = \sum_{u \leq t, (u, d')=1} w(u) = M_{d'} t + E_{d'}(t)$, so that $E_{d'}(t) \ll t^{1/2+\varepsilon'} d'^{\varepsilon'}$ by Lemma 10(i). Stieltjes integration and the substitution $t = H/Y$ give

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{\substack{u > U_0 \\ (u, d')=1}} w(u) \bar{G}_{d'}(H/u) &= \int_{U_0}^{\infty} \bar{G}_{d'}(H/t) dA_{d'}(t) \\ &= M_{d'} H \int_0^{Y_0} \bar{G}_{d'}(Y) \frac{dY}{Y^2} + R_{d'}, \\ R_{d'} &= -\bar{G}_{d'}(Y_0) E_{d'}(U_0) - \int_{U_0}^{\infty} E_{d'}(t) \partial_t [\bar{G}_{d'}(H/t)] dt, \end{aligned}$$

the boundary term at infinity vanishing because $|\bar{G}_{d'}(H/t)| \leq \omega H^2/(2d't^2)$ for $t > H$. By Lemma 11(a),(b),(c),

$$\int_{U_0}^H |\partial_t \bar{G}_{d'}(H/t)| dt = \int_1^{Y_0} |\partial_Y \bar{G}_{d'}| dY \leq \omega(d') Y_0 \quad \text{and} \quad \int_H^{\infty} t^{1/2+\varepsilon'} \frac{\omega H^2}{d' t^3} dt \ll \frac{\omega H^{1/2+\varepsilon'}}{d'},$$

so $R_{d'} \ll \omega(d')d'^{\varepsilon'}(\sigma(d')/\varphi(d') + Y_0)H^{1/2+\varepsilon'}$ and $\sum_{d' \leq H^{1/3}}(\lambda(d')/d')|R_{d'}| \ll H^{1/2+1/3+3\varepsilon'}$. For $d' > H^{1/3}$ we bound the two sides separately: for $U_0 < u \leq H$ we have $H/u \leq Y_0 < d'$, so by (a) and (b) $\sum_{u>U_0} w(u)|\bar{G}_{d'}(H/u)| \ll (\omega\tau/\varphi)(\sum_{U_0<u\leq H} w(u)H/u + \sum_{u>H} w(u)H^2/u^2) \ll (\omega\tau(d')/\varphi(d'))H \log H$, and $M_{d'}H \int_0^{Y_0} |\bar{G}_{d'}|Y^{-2}dY \ll (\omega\tau/\varphi)H \log H$ as well; summing (λ/d') · these over $d' > H^{1/3}$ gives $\ll H^{2/3+\varepsilon'} \log H$. Finally the tails of the integrals: by (a), for $d' \leq Y_0$, $\int_{Y_0}^\infty |\bar{G}_{d'}|Y^{-2}dY \leq \sigma/(8Y_0)$, and for $d' > Y_0$ it is $\leq \int_{Y_0}^{d'} \frac{\tau dY}{2Y} + \int_{d'}^\infty \frac{\sigma dY}{8Y^2} \ll \tau(d')(1 + \log(d'/Y_0))$, whence $\sum_{d'}(\lambda M_{d'}/d') \int_{Y_0}^\infty |\bar{G}_{d'}|Y^{-2}dY \ll Y_0^{-1} \log Y_0 + Y_0^{-1+\varepsilon'}$. The same bounds with Y_0 replaced by 1, together with (b) below 1, show that the series defining c_{off} in (15) converges absolutely. Altogether $\mathcal{M}(H) = c_{\text{off}}(f)H + O(H^{5/6+3\varepsilon'} + H^{2/3+2\varepsilon'} \log H)$, and with (16) the theorem follows with $\delta = \varepsilon/5$. The second expression for c_{off} is Lemma 11(e), and it is negative since every term is. $\square$

In words. When the agreeing part u is much larger than the length $Y = H/u$, the dilation $\bar{u}$ runs through all units modulo d' as u runs through a dyadic range, so the root set may be replaced by its average over all dilations; this costs the error of Lemma 10, and Parseval on the group of units keeps that cost to $\sqrt{\varphi(d')}$ rather than $\varphi(d')$ times the error per class, which is what fixes the range $u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$. The average over dilations is not zero: a root is an integer ≥ 1 , and the Cesàro weight $Y - x$ sees the gap between the discrete count and the continuous expectation $Y^2/(2d')$. Integrated over the length this gap has a remarkably simple value, $-\log p/(p-1)$ for a prime modulus and exactly 0 for a composite one, which is where the closed formula (15) comes from. The dilation, which is the obstacle for small u , is the mechanism for large u ; but it leaves a main term.

Corollary 13 (the constant, and the mean of the sharp off-diagonal). *Let $\text{Off}_f(t) = \sum_d W_f(d) \sum_{s \neq s'} \psi_d(s' - s, t)$ be the sharp off-diagonal of part I, where $\psi_d(m, t) = \#\{h \leq t : h \equiv m \pmod{d}\} - t/d$. Then*

$$\text{Off}_f^*(H) = \sum_{t < H} \text{Off}_f(t) - \frac{\kappa_f}{2}H, \quad \kappa_f = \sum_d W_f(d) \frac{\omega(d)(\omega(d)-1)}{d} = 1 - D_f(1), \quad (17)$$

where $D_f(1) = \sum_{d \geq 1} a_f(d)/d$ is the value at 1 of the diagonal Dirichlet series of part I, the term $d = 1$ (equal to $P(1)$) included. Consequently, if the pieces with $u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$ contribute $o(H)$ to $\text{Off}_f^*(H)$ (Theorem 19 below gives this under Hypothesis W), then $\text{Off}_f^*(H) \sim c_{\text{off}}(f)H$, the Cesàro constant of Conjecture 1 of part I is the diagonal constant plus $C(f)^2 c_{\text{off}}(f)$, and the sharp off-diagonal $\text{Off}_f(t)$ has mean value

$$\lim_{H \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1}{H} \sum_{t \leq H} \text{Off}_f(t) = c_{\text{off}}(f) + \frac{1 - D_f(1)}{2}.$$

Proof. For integer H , $B_d^{(H)}(m) = \sum_{t < H} \#\{h \leq t : h \equiv m\} - H^2/(2d) = \sum_{t < H} \psi_d(m, t) + H(H-1)/(2d) - H^2/(2d)$, and the number of ordered pairs $s \neq s'$ is $\omega(d)(\omega(d)-1)$; the identity $\sum_d W_f(d)\omega(d)^2/d = 1$ is the statement that S_f has mean value $C(f)^2$ (part I, Theorem 2), and $\sum_d W_f(d)\omega(d)/d = \sum_d a_f(d)/d = D_f(1)$. $\square$

Numerical check for $f = t^2 + 1$. Here $w(2u') = 4A_0\lambda(u')\omega(u')$ with $A_0 = \prod_{p \equiv 1(4)} P_p = 0.51747684\dots$ (w vanishes on odd u , see the set-up), $D_f(1) = 0.75079081\dots$ (part II), and (15) evaluates to $c_{\text{off}}(t^2 + 1) = -0.134390$ (research/paper-III/scripts/coff.py: $m = 0.728431$, prime sum 0.184492 over $p \equiv 1(4)$, $p \leq 2 \cdot 10^6$). The corollary then predicts the mean of $\text{Off}_f(t)$ to be $-0.134390 + 0.124605 = -0.00978$. The exact values of $\text{Off}_f(t)$ for all $t \leq 10^7$

(`research/paper-III/scripts/offstar-mean.ts`, from the identity of part I with the constants of part II) have the following means over consecutive dyadic blocks ending at $2^{17}, \dots, 2^{23}$:

$$-0.0106, \quad -0.0101, \quad -0.0096, \quad -0.0115, \quad -0.0088, \quad -0.0099, \quad -0.0096,$$

and cumulative mean -0.00945 at $t = 10^7$ (-0.0102 at 10^6); the standard deviation of $\text{Off}_f(t)$ is 0.50 , so a block of 2^{16} values has statistical scatter about 0.002 even before arithmetic correlations. The measured mean, -0.0098 ± 0.0007 , agrees with the prediction to within the scatter: in terms of c_{off} , -0.1344 ± 0.0007 against -0.13439 . Since the prediction uses only the pieces with $u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$, the agreement is numerical evidence that the pieces with small u , the window included, are $o(H)$ for $t^2 + 1$, as Theorem 19 asserts under Hypothesis W. The near-cancellation of c_{off} against $(1 - D_f(1))/2$ is what made Off_f look mean-zero in the numerics of part II.

The same test for three further quadratics (`research/paper-III/scripts/off-general.ts`, exact $\text{Off}_f(t)$ for all $t \leq 10^7$; here $P(1) \neq 0$ and $D_f(1)$ includes the term $d = 1$):

f	$C(f)$	$c_{\text{off}}(f)$	$\frac{1}{2}(1 - D_f(1))$	predicted mean	measured mean (dyadic blocks 2^{20} – 2^{23})
$t^2 + t + 41$	6.640	-0.002247	0.003553	0.00131	0.00144 (0.00118 to 0.00150)
$t^2 + t + 17$	4.175	-0.011305	0.014713	0.00341	0.00362 (0.00342 to 0.00367)
$2t^2 + 1$	1.426	-0.428619	0.976896	0.54828	0.54820 (0.5463 to 0.5501)

For $2t^2 + 1$ the weights have both signs ($\omega(3) = 2$, $\lambda(3) = -3$, $P(1) = -2.727$) and the constants are large; the agreement to three digits shows that the identity behind Corollary 13 and the main term of Theorem 12 do not depend on positivity. In all four cases the mean of the sharp off-diagonal is a small difference of two computable constants, and the data leave no room for a contribution of size $\gg 10^{-3}$ from the pieces with $u \leq H^{2/3}$.

5 The window, Hypothesis W and Theorem A

5.1 Where the difficulty sits

Collecting Sections 3.2–4: in the piece u , the moduli $d' \leq Y$ are unconditional with a logarithmic saving (Theorem 6), the moduli $d' > u^2 Y L$ are $O(Y/(u^2 L))$ for trivial reasons (Lemma 7), and the pieces with $u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$ are Theorem 12, main term included. What is left, for $1 < u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$, is the *window*

$$\mathcal{W}_u(Y; L) = \sum_{Y < d' \leq u^2 Y L} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \sum_{x \in R_{d'}^{(u)}} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) = \sum_{Y < d' \leq u^2 Y L} \frac{\lambda(d')}{d'} \left[\sum_{\substack{x \in R_{d'}^{(u)} \\ \langle x \rangle_{d'} \leq Y}} (Y - \langle x \rangle_{d'}) - \frac{\omega(d') Y^2}{2d'} \right], \quad (18)$$

in which the interval $[1, Y]$ covers a fraction $Y/d' \in [(u^2 L)^{-1}, 1)$ of a period. It is empty for $u = 1$, $L = 1$, and its trivial size is $O(Y)$ (Proposition 1, whose bound for $d' > Y$ applies to any range of moduli above Y). Summarising:

Theorem 14 (A' : unconditional reduction). *For every irreducible quadratic f and every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is $c = c(f) > 0$ such that*

$$\text{Off}_f^*(H) = c_{\text{off}}(f) H + \sum_{u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}} w(u) \mathcal{W}_u\left(\frac{H}{u}; \log H\right) + O_{f,\varepsilon}(H(\log H)^{1-c}).$$

In particular the Cesàro form of Hypothesis (E), $\text{Off}_f^(H) = o(H \log H)$, holds if and only if $\sum_{u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}} w(u) \mathcal{W}_u(H/u; \log H) = o(H \log H)$.*

Proof. Proposition 1, Theorem 12 for $u > H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$, and for $u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$ (so $Y = H/u \geq H^{1/3-\varepsilon}$) the split $\mathcal{P}_u(Y) = \mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(Y) + \mathcal{W}_u(Y; \log H) + \mathcal{P}_u^{\text{far}}(Y; \log H)$ with Theorem 6 (applicable since $Y \geq \exp((\log \log u)^3)$) and Lemma 7: $\sum_{u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}} w(u) [(H/u)(\log H)^{-c} + H/(u^3 \log H)] \ll H(\log H)^{1-c}$. $\square$

The window is where the two mechanisms of this paper both fail, except at the two ends of the range of u . Koksma's inequality with the function $(Y - \theta d')^+$, of variation Y , gives $|\mathcal{W}_u(Y; L)| \ll Y \sum_{Y < d' \leq u^2 Y L} |\lambda| \omega(d') \text{disc}(\Delta_{d'}^{(u)})/d' \ll Y(1 + \log(u^2 L))(\log Y)^{-c}$ by Proposition 4 and partial summation, which is a saving only while $\log u \ll (\log Y)^c$: summed against $w(u)/u$ over all $u \leq H^{2/3}$ it produces $H(\log H)^{2-c}$, which exceeds $H \log H$ since $c < 1$. The averaging of Theorem 12 needs $Y < u^{1/2}$.

Corollary 15 (small agreeing part). *With $c = c(f)$ as in Theorem 6 and $U_1 = \exp((\log H)^{c/3})$, $\sum_{u \leq U_1} w(u) \mathcal{W}_u(H/u; \log H) \ll_f H(\log H)^{-c/3}$. Hence in Theorem 14 the sum over u may be restricted to $U_1 < u \leq H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$: the windows of the pieces with $u \leq \exp((\log H)^{c/3})$ contribute $o(H)$ unconditionally.*

Proof. For $u \leq U_1$, $Y = H/u \geq H^{1/2}$ and $\log(u^2 \log H) \ll (\log H)^{c/3}$, so the bound above gives $\mathcal{W}_u(H/u; \log H) \ll (H/u)(\log H)^{c/3-c}$, and $\sum_{u \leq U_1} |w(u)|/u \ll \log U_1 = (\log H)^{c/3}$. $\square$

In the original variables the window consists of the moduli $d = ud' \in (H, u^2 HL]$ with agreeing part u , and the count is that of the roots $X \leq H$ of $X^2 \equiv D \pmod{d'}$ divisible by u : a short-interval problem for the roots of a quadratic congruence, at the scale $Y/d' \geq (u^2 L)^{-1}$ of the period.

5.2 The window in Fourier form

Lemma 16 (finite Fourier expansion). *Let $d' \geq 3$ be odd, $R \subset \mathbb{Z}/d'$ symmetric ($x \in R \Rightarrow -x \in R$) with $0 \notin R$, $Y \geq 1$ an integer, and $\rho_k = \sum_{x \in R} e(kx/d')$ (real). Then*

$$\sum_{x \in R} B_{d'}^{(Y)}(\langle x \rangle_{d'}) = \frac{1}{4d'} \sum_{0 < k < d'} \frac{1 - \cos(2\pi k Y/d')}{\sin^2(\pi k/d')} \rho_k = \frac{1}{2d'} \sum_{0 < k < d'/2} \frac{1 - \cos(2\pi k Y/d')}{\sin^2(\pi k/d')} \rho_k. \quad (19)$$

For $0 < k \leq d'/2$ the coefficient satisfies

$$0 \leq \frac{1 - \cos(2\pi k Y/d')}{4d' \sin^2(\pi k/d')} \leq \frac{1}{d'} \min\left(\frac{d'^2}{8k^2}, \frac{\pi^2 Y^2}{8}\right).$$

Proof. Let $F(m) = B_{d'}^{(Y)}(m)$, a function on $\mathbb{Z}/d'$, with Fourier coefficients $\hat{F}(k) = d'^{-1} \sum_m F(m) e(-km/d')$, so that $\sum_{x \in R} F(x) = \sum_{k \bmod d'} \hat{F}(k) \rho_k$. For $k \equiv 0$,

$$\hat{F}(0) = d'^{-1} \left(\sum_{h \leq Y} (Y - h) - \frac{Y^2}{2} \right) = -\frac{Y}{2d'}.$$

For $k \not\equiv 0$ put $\alpha = k/d'$; since $\sum_m (Y^2/2d') e(-km/d') = 0$,

$$\hat{F}(k) = \frac{1}{d'} \sum_{h \leq Y} (Y - h) e(-h\alpha) = \frac{1}{d'} \sum_{j=0}^{Y-1} \sum_{h=1}^j e(-h\alpha) = \frac{1}{d'} \frac{e(-\alpha)}{1 - e(-\alpha)} \left[Y - \frac{1 - e(-Y\alpha)}{1 - e(-\alpha)} \right].$$

Now $e(-\alpha)/(1 - e(-\alpha)) = 1/(e(\alpha) - 1)$ has real part $-\frac{1}{2}$, and $e(-\alpha)/(1 - e(-\alpha))^2 \cdot (1 - e(-Y\alpha)) = -(1 - e(-Y\alpha))/(4 \sin^2 \pi \alpha)$ has real part $-(1 - \cos 2\pi Y \alpha)/(4 \sin^2 \pi \alpha)$. Hence $\Re \hat{F}(k) = -Y/(2d') + (1 - \cos(2\pi k Y/d'))/(4d' \sin^2(\pi k/d'))$. Since ρ_k is real and $\rho_{-k} = \rho_k$, $\sum_k \hat{F}(k) \rho_k = \sum_k \Re \hat{F}(k) \rho_k$,

and $\sum_{k \neq 0} \rho_k = \sum_{x \in R} \sum_{k \neq 0} e(kx/d') = -|R|$ because $0 \notin R$; so the terms $-Y/(2d')$ contribute $-|R|Y/(2d') + |R|Y/(2d') = 0$, which is the first equality. The second is the symmetry $k \leftrightarrow d' - k$ (d' odd). For the bound, $1 - \cos \phi \leq \min(2, \phi^2/2)$ and $\sin(\pi k/d') \geq 2k/d'$ for $0 < k \leq d'/2$. $\square$

For $d' \leq Y$, (19) is (5) with the frequencies folded modulo d' . The bound in the lemma shows what the window is made of: for $d' > Y$ the frequencies $k \leq d'/Y$ carry the flat weight $\asymp Y^2/d'$ each, and only beyond $k \asymp d'/Y$ does the k^{-2} decay begin. A modulus $d' \in (Y, u^2YL]$ therefore has up to u^2L frequencies of full weight, and any Fourier-side treatment must control the Weyl sums $\rho_k(d')$ for k up to u^2L , with a loss in k small enough to be paid by the saving in the modulus. This is the source of the exponent condition in Theorem A.

Hypothesis 17 ($W(\theta, B)$). *There are $\theta \in (0, 1)$ and $B \geq 0$ such that for all squarefree u with $\omega(u) \geq 1$, all $k \geq 1$, $t \geq 2$ and $\varepsilon > 0$,*

$$S_k(t) = \sum_{\substack{d' \leq t \\ (d', u)=1, d' \text{ split}}} \lambda(d') \sum_{x: u^2x^2 \equiv D \pmod{d'}} e\left(\frac{kx}{d'}\right) \ll_{f, \varepsilon} (uk)^B t^{\theta + \varepsilon}.$$

Proposition 18 (the window from Weyl sums). *Assume Hypothesis $W(\theta, B)$ with $\theta + B < 1$. Then for squarefree u with $\omega(u) \geq 1$, $Y \geq 2$, $L \geq 1$ and $\varepsilon > 0$,*

$$\mathcal{W}_u(Y; L) \ll_{f, \varepsilon} (u^{3B}L^B + u^BY^B)Y^{\theta + 2\varepsilon} + Y^{1 - \varepsilon}.$$

Proof. By Lemma 16 (all d' are odd, $R_{d'}^{(u)}$ is symmetric and avoids 0),

$$\mathcal{W}_u(Y; L) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{k \geq 1} \sum_{\substack{Y < d' \leq u^2YL \\ d' > 2k}} \lambda(d') \rho_k(d') g_k(d'), \quad g_k(d') = \frac{1 - \cos(2\pi kY/d')}{d'^2 \sin^2(\pi k/d')},$$

the interchange being legitimate since all sums are finite. Let $K = u^2LY^\varepsilon$. For $k > K$ we use $0 \leq g_k(d') \leq 1/(2k^2)$ (from $\sin(\pi k/d') \geq 2k/d'$ for $d' \geq 2k$) and $|\rho_k| \leq \omega(d')$: the contribution is $\leq \sum_{d' \leq u^2YL} \lambda\omega(d') \sum_{k > K} k^{-2} \ll u^2YL/K = Y^{1 - \varepsilon}$.

For $k \leq K$ we sum by parts in d' over dyadic blocks $V < d' \leq 2V$ covering $(\max(Y, 2k), u^2YL]$, so $V \geq Y/2$ and $V \geq k$. On a block write $g_k = ab$ with $a(d') = 1 - \cos(2\pi kY/d')$ and $b(d') = (d' \sin(\pi k/d'))^{-2}$. Since $t \mapsto t \sin(\pi k/t)$ increases for $t > k$ and equals at least $2k$ for $t \geq 2k$, b is decreasing on the block with $b \leq 1/(4k^2)$, so $\text{Var } b \leq \sup b \leq 1/(4k^2)$. The phase $2\pi kY/d'$ decreases over the block through an interval of length $\pi kY/V$, so a has $\sup a \leq \min(2, 2\pi^2 k^2 Y^2/V^2)$ and $\text{Var } a \leq 2 \sup a \cdot (kY/V + 1)$. Hence on the block

$$\begin{aligned} \sup g_k + \text{Var } g_k &\leq 2 \sup a \sup b + \sup a \text{Var } b + \sup b \text{Var } a \\ &\ll \frac{\min(1, k^2 Y^2/V^2)}{k^2} \left(1 + \frac{kY}{V}\right) \ll \begin{cases} k^{-2} + Y/(kV) & (V \leq kY), \\ Y^2/V^2 & (V > kY). \end{cases} \end{aligned}$$

Partial summation against S_k (Hypothesis W: $\sup_{t \leq 2V} |S_k(t)| \ll (uk)^B (2V)^{\theta + \varepsilon}$) gives for the block $|\sum_{V < d' \leq 2V} \lambda \rho_k g_k| \leq 2 \sup_{t \leq 2V} |S_k(t)| (\sup g_k + \text{Var } g_k)$, and summing over the dyadic V : the terms $V^\theta k^{-2}$ ($V \leq kY$) and $V^\theta Y^2/V^2$ ($V > kY$) are largest at $V = kY$, giving $\ll (uk)^B (kY)^{\theta + \varepsilon} k^{-2}$; the term $V^{\theta - 1} Y/k$ is largest at the smallest block, $V \asymp \max(Y, k)$, giving $\ll (uk)^B Y^{\theta + \varepsilon} k^{-1}$ if $2k \leq Y$ and $\ll (uk)^B Y k^{\theta - 2 + \varepsilon}$ if $2k > Y$. As $\theta < 1$, in all

$$\left| \sum_{d' > \max(Y, 2k)} \lambda \rho_k g_k \right| \ll u^B Y^{\theta + \varepsilon} k^{B - 1} \quad (2k \leq Y), \quad \ll u^B Y^{1 + \varepsilon} k^{B + \theta - 2} \quad (2k > Y).$$

Summing over $k \leq \min(K, Y/2)$ gives $\ll u^B Y^{\theta + \varepsilon} (K^B \log K) \ll u^{3B} L^B Y^{\theta + 2\varepsilon}$, and over $Y/2 < k \leq K$ (using $B + \theta < 1$) $\ll u^B Y^{1 + \varepsilon} Y^{B + \theta - 1} = u^B Y^{B + \theta + \varepsilon}$. $\square$

Theorem 19 (A). Let f be an irreducible quadratic and assume Hypothesis $W(\theta, B)$ with

$$\theta + 6B < 1. \quad (20)$$

Then there is $\delta = \delta(\theta, B) > 0$ with $\text{Off}_f^*(H) = c_{\text{off}}(f)H + O_f(H^{1-\delta})$, and consequently

$$\sum_{h \leq H} \left(1 - \frac{h}{H}\right) (S_f(h) - C(f)^2) = -\frac{1}{2}C(f) \log H + A_f + o(1), \quad A_f = A_f^{\text{diag}} + C(f)^2 c_{\text{off}}(f),$$

Conjecture 1 of part I in Cesàro form, where A_f^{diag} is the constant term of the diagonal (part I, Theorem 6; that the $O_f(1)$ there is $A_f^{\text{diag}} + o(1)$ follows from the Perron integral of $\zeta(s)D_f(s)H^{s+1}/(s(s+1))$ shifted past $\Re s = 0$ using the zero-free region of ζ_K , the double pole at $s = 0$ producing the $\log H$ and the constant; the rate of the $o(1)$ is governed by the zeros of ζ_K as in part II, Proposition 7).

Proof. Let $\varepsilon > 0$ be small, $U_0 = H^{2/3+\varepsilon}$, $L = H^\varepsilon$. By Theorem 12 the pieces $u > U_0$ give $c_{\text{off}}H + O(H^{1-\delta_0})$. For $u \leq U_0$ write $Y = H/u \geq H^{1/3-\varepsilon}$ and split $\mathcal{P}_u(Y) = \mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(Y) + \mathcal{W}_u(Y; L) + \mathcal{P}_u^{\text{far}}(Y; L)$. All sums over u below are against $|w(u)|$, and we use $\sum_{u \leq U} |w(u)|u^a \ll U^{1+a}$ for $a > -1$ (Proposition 1).

Far moduli. Lemma 7: $\sum_{u \leq U_0} |w(u)|H/(u^3L) \ll H^{1-\varepsilon}$.

Small moduli. Hypothesis W is (7), so Lemma 2 gives $T_k(Y) \ll (uk)^B(kY)^{1/(2-\theta)+\varepsilon}$, and in (6) $\sum_{k \leq K'} k^{-2}|T_k| \ll u^B Y^{1/(2-\theta)+\varepsilon} \sum_{k \leq K'} k^{-2+B+1/(2-\theta)+\varepsilon} \ll u^B Y^{1/(2-\theta)+\varepsilon}$, the exponent of k being < -1 because $B < (1-\theta)/6 < (1-\theta)/(2-\theta)$; the tail $k > K'$ is $\ll Y/K'$ trivially, and $K' = Y$ suffices. Hence $\sum_{u \leq U_0} |w(u)|\mathcal{P}_u^{\leq}(H/u) \ll H^{1/(2-\theta)+\varepsilon} \sum_{u \leq U_0} |w(u)|u^{B-1/(2-\theta)} \ll H^{1/(2-\theta)+(2/3)(1+B-1/(2-\theta))+O(\varepsilon)}$, and the exponent is < 1 exactly when $2B(2-\theta) < 1-\theta$, which follows from (20) since $(1-\theta)/6 < (1-\theta)/(2(2-\theta))$.

Window. Proposition 18 with $Y = H/u$:

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{u \leq U_0} |w(u)| \mathcal{W}_u\left(\frac{H}{u}; L\right) &\ll H^{\theta+O(\varepsilon)} \sum_{u \leq U_0} |w(u)|u^{3B-\theta} + H^{\theta+B+O(\varepsilon)} \sum_{u \leq U_0} |w(u)|u^{-\theta-B} \\ &\quad + \sum_{u \leq U_0} |w(u)|\left(\frac{H}{u}\right)^{1-\varepsilon} \end{aligned}$$

$\ll H^{\theta+(2/3)(1+3B-\theta)+O(\varepsilon)} + H^{\theta+B+(2/3)(1-\theta-B)+O(\varepsilon)} + H^{1-\varepsilon/3}$. The first exponent is $\frac{2}{3} + \frac{1}{3}\theta + 2B < 1$ exactly when $\theta + 6B < 1$; the second is $\frac{2}{3} + \frac{1}{3}(\theta + B) < 1$, which is weaker. Choosing ε small gives $\text{Off}_f^*(H) = c_{\text{off}}H + O(H^{1-\delta})$; the consequence is (2). $\square$

Remark 20 (what the exponents say). The condition $\theta + 6B < 1$ is satisfied by every $\theta < 1$ when $B = 0$: any power saving in the modulus closes the window, provided the loss in the dilation u and the frequency k is below $(uk)^{(1-\theta)/6}$. It is not satisfied by the exponents $(\theta, B) = (\frac{3}{4}, \frac{1}{4})$ of [1] (their $h^{1/4}$ is our k^B), nor by $(\frac{11}{12}, \frac{1}{4})$ of Lemma 8, because of B , not θ . So the bottleneck is the dependence on the frequency and on the dilation, not the exponent in the modulus. The reason is the flat spectrum of the window (Lemma 16): at a modulus $d' \in (Y, u^2YL]$ the frequencies $k \leq d'/Y$ carry equal weight, so the Weyl sums must be summed over k up to u^2L with the loss k^B , and $\sum_{k \leq u^2L} k^{B-1} \asymp (u^2L)^B$ is then multiplied by the trivial-in- u factor u^B ; the total loss u^{3B} against a gain $Y^{-(1-\theta)} = (H/u)^{-(1-\theta)}$ is affordable up to $u \leq H^{2/3}$ exactly when $\theta + 6B < 1$. The range $2/3$ of Theorem 12 enters through the factor $\frac{2}{3}$; with an averaging argument valid for $u > H^{1/2+\varepsilon}$ the condition would be $\theta + 3B < 1$. A Weyl-sum bound with $B = 0$, i.e. uniform in the frequency and the dilation, is a strong statement: for $u = 1$ and k large it is the assertion that the roots of $x^2 \equiv D \pmod{d'}$, averaged over $d' \leq t$, are equidistributed at scales $1/k$ down to $t^{-(1-\theta)}$ with no loss, which is beyond [1] but is what the numerics of Remark 21 suggest is true.

Remark 21 (the size of the pieces). The pieces can be computed exactly, and their size says how far the truth is from what is needed. For $f = t^2 + 1$ the piece is $\mathcal{P}_u(Y) = \sum_{h \leq Y} (Y - h)(F_u(Q'_u(h)) - \mathbb{E}F_u) - (\mathbb{E}F_u - 1)Y/2$ with $Q'_u(h) = (u/2)^2 h^2 + 1$, $F_u(n) = \prod_{p|n, p \equiv 1(4), p \nmid u} (1 + \frac{1}{p-4})$ and $\mathbb{E}F_u = \prod_{p \equiv 1(4), p \nmid u} (1 + \frac{2}{p(p-4)})$ (the divisor-sum form of (4): $F_u(n) = \sum_{d'|n} \lambda(d')/d'$), which is a sieve computation (`research/paper-IV/scripts/piece.ts`, with $\mathbb{E}F_u$ to 22 digits). For $u \in \{2, 10, 26, 130\}$ and $Y \leq 10^7$ (resp. 10^6) we find $|\mathcal{P}_u(Y)| \leq 0.4\sqrt{Y}$ throughout, e.g. $\mathcal{P}_2(10^7) = 42.7$ and $\mathcal{P}_{10}(10^7) = 229.8$, against the trivial size $Y \log(u^2 L)$; and the sharp pieces $S_u(t) = \sum_{h \leq t} (F_u(Q'_u(h)) - \mathbb{E}F_u)$, which are trivially $O(\log t)$, stay below 1.3 in absolute value for all $t \leq 10^7$. So the off-diagonal pieces exhibit square-root cancellation: each prime $p \mid Q'_u(h)$ contributes a sawtooth of size $1/p$ in t , and the sawtooths at different moduli cancel like independent signs. This is the same phenomenon as in the diagonal sum $\sum_d a_f(d)(\{H/d\} - \frac{1}{2})$ of part I, where the Dirichlet series proves it. Moreover, the oscillations of $\mathcal{P}_u(Y)/\sqrt{Y}$ in $\log Y$ are, for five quadratics tested, those of the even Maass cusp forms of $\mathrm{SL}_2(\mathbb{Z})$ (spectral parameters 13.78, 17.74, 19.42, ...; the odd ones are absent), and the discriminants for which no such oscillation is visible are those whose Katok–Sarnak periods at the Heegner points are exponentially small. Part IV of this series [4] gives a spectral argument for the corresponding asymptotic for $u = 1$ (with a gap at one step, recorded there on 13 September 2026, so that it is not yet a theorem): the root pairs of a quadratic congruence are the Heegner points of its discriminant, the piece is a sum of one test function over their modular orbit, and its spectral expansion produces $\sqrt{Y} Y^{it_j}$ with amplitudes the periods, only the even forms surviving. What Theorem 14 needs, $o(Y)$ per piece on average, is very far from this truth.

In words. Two mechanisms are in place, and they meet with a gap between them. For pieces with a large agreeing part the dilations average out along u , leaving the main term $c_{\mathrm{off}}H$; for small moduli in every piece the Chinese remainder theorem alone equidistributes the dilated roots. Neither reaches the window: the moduli just above the length, where an interval covers a fraction between u^{-2} and 1 of a period. Hypothesis W closes the window provided its exponents satisfy (20), and the numerics for $t^2 + 1$ (the mean of the sharp off-diagonal agrees with $c_{\mathrm{off}} + (1 - D_f(1))/2$ to three digits) say that for that polynomial the windows are indeed $o(H)$. We have not proved it, and we want to be clear that the window is not a technical remainder: it is the off-diagonal problem itself, stated precisely, with everything else removed.

6 The function field: the off-diagonal has a main term

Let $\mathcal{A} = \mathbb{F}_q[u]$, q odd, $f = t^2 - D$ with $D \in \mathcal{A}$ squarefree of positive degree, and define ω_f , λ , $P(1)$, W_f as over $\mathbb{Z}$ with $|P| = q^{\deg P}$. Part I, Theorem 8 and Lemma 9: for $N \geq 1$, with the sum over the $q^N - 1$ nonzero h of degree $< N$,

$$\sum_h \left(\frac{S_f(h)}{C^2} - 1 \right) = - \sum_{1 \leq \deg d \leq N} a_f(d) - q^N \sum_{\deg d > N} \frac{a_f(d)}{|d|} + (1 - P(1)) + \mathrm{Off}_f(N), \quad (21)$$

$$\mathrm{Off}_f(N) = T_{\mathrm{act}}(N) - T_{\mathrm{exp}}(N),$$

$$T_{\mathrm{act}}(N) = \sum_{N < \deg d \leq M(N)} W_f(d) A_N(d), \quad T_{\mathrm{exp}}(N) = q^N \sum_{\deg d > N} \frac{W_f(d)(\omega_f(d)^2 - \omega_f(d))}{|d|},$$

where $A_N(d)$ is the number of ordered pairs of distinct roots of f modulo d whose difference has degree $< N$ and $M(N) = N - 1 + \max(2N - 2, \deg D)$. Here $\mathrm{Off}_f(N)$ is the exact off-diagonal (no Cesàro weight is needed: over $\mathcal{A}$ the small moduli contribute nothing).

Theorem 22. *Let $D = u$. Then, as $q \rightarrow \infty$ through odd prime powers,*

$$\text{Off}_f(1) = -\frac{2}{q} + O\left(\frac{1}{q^2}\right), \quad \text{Off}_f(2) = -\frac{2}{q} + O\left(\frac{1}{q^{3/2}}\right).$$

More precisely $T_{\text{exp}}(1) = 2/q + O(q^{-2})$, $T_{\text{act}}(1) = 0$, $T_{\text{exp}}(2) = 3/q + O(q^{-3/2})$, $T_{\text{act}}(2) = 1/q + O(q^{-3/2})$.

Proof. Prime counts. For $D = u$ the character χ_D has conductor of degree 1, so its L -function is 1 and $\sum_{\deg P|k} \deg P \cdot \chi_D(P)^{k/\deg P} = 0$ for every $k \geq 1$. With π_k the number of monic irreducible polynomials of degree k ($\pi_1 = q$, $\pi_2 = (q^2 - q)/2$, $\pi_3 = (q^3 - q)/3$) this gives exactly: split linear primes $(q-1)/2$ (the $a \in \mathbb{F}_q^\times$ with $\chi(a) = 1$, χ the quadratic character of $\mathbb{F}_q$), one special prime u ($\omega = 1$), inert linear primes $(q-1)/2$; split quadratic primes $(\pi_2 - (q-1)/2)/2 = (q-1)^2/4$; split cubic primes $\pi_3/2$. For general D the same counts hold up to $O(q^{k/2})$ by Weil's bound, which is why the error term would be $O(q^{-3/2})$ in general; for $D = u$ and $N = 1$ everything is exact and the error is $O(q^{-2})$.

Local factors. At a split prime of norm Q , $\lambda = Q/(Q-4) = 1 + 4/Q + O(Q^{-2})$ and $P_P = 1 - 4/(Q-2)^2$; at u , $\lambda = q/(q-2)$; at inert primes $\lambda = P_P = 1$. Hence $P(1) = \prod_{\text{split linear}} (1 - 4/(q-2)^2) \cdot (1 + O(q^{-2})) = 1 - 2/q + O(q^{-2})$.

$T_{\text{exp}}(1)$. $T_{\text{exp}}(1) = q P(1) \sum_{\deg d \geq 2} \lambda(d) \omega^\circ(d)/|d|^2$ with $\omega^\circ = \omega^2 - \omega$, over squarefree d with $\omega(d) \geq 2$. Degree 2: split quadratic primes, $\omega^\circ = 2$, count $(q-1)^2/4$, weight λ/q^4 ; products of two distinct split linear primes, $\omega = 4$, $\omega^\circ = 12$, count $\binom{(q-1)/2}{2}$; u times a split linear prime, $\omega^\circ = 2$, count $(q-1)/2$. So $\sum_{\deg d=2} \lambda \omega^\circ = 2 \cdot \frac{q^2}{4} + 12 \cdot \frac{q^2}{8} + O(q) = 2q^2 + O(q)$, and degree ≥ 3 contributes $q \cdot O(q^3 \cdot q^{-6}) = O(q^{-2})$. Hence $T_{\text{exp}}(1) = q(1 + O(q^{-1}))(2q^2 + O(q))q^{-4} = 2/q + O(q^{-2})$. $T_{\text{act}}(1) = 0$ since $M(1) = 1$ leaves no modulus.

$T_{\text{exp}}(2)$. Degree 3 squarefree d with $\omega(d) \geq 2$: split cubic primes, $\omega^\circ = 2$, count $\pi_3/2 = q^3/6 + O(q)$; split linear $\times$ split quadratic, $\omega^\circ = 12$, count $\frac{q-1}{2} \cdot \frac{(q-1)^2}{4} = q^3/8 + O(q^2)$; three distinct split linear, $\omega = 8$, $\omega^\circ = 56$, count $\binom{(q-1)/2}{3} = q^3/48 + O(q^2)$; terms with u are $O(q^2)$. So $\sum_{\deg d=3} \lambda \omega^\circ = q^3(\frac{2}{6} + \frac{12}{8} + \frac{56}{48}) + O(q^2) = 3q^3 + O(q^2)$, degree ≥ 4 gives $q^2 \cdot O(q^4 q^{-8}) = O(q^{-2})$, and $T_{\text{exp}}(2) = q^2(1 + O(q^{-1})) \cdot 3q^3 q^{-6} = 3/q + O(q^{-2})$.

$T_{\text{act}}(2)$. $M(2) = 3$, so the moduli have degree 3. A pair (s, s') , $s' = -s$ on the differing part d' and $s' = s$ on $d_2 = d/d'$, has difference $m = s' - s$ with $d_2 \mid m$ and $d' \mid m^2 - 4u$ (Lemma 9 of part I: $m \equiv -2s \pmod{d'}$, so $m^2 \equiv 4s^2 \equiv 4u$). For $\deg m \leq 1$: if $d_2 = 1$ then $\deg(m^2 - 4u) \leq 2 < 3 = \deg d$ forces $m^2 = 4u$, impossible; if $\deg d_2 = 2$ then $d_2 \mid m$ forces $m = 0$, excluded; so $\deg d_2 = 1$, $m = cd_2$ with $c \in \mathbb{F}_q^\times$, and $d' \mid c^2 d_2^2 - 4u$ with $\deg d' = 2 = \deg(c^2 d_2^2 - 4u)$, i.e. $d' = d_2^2 - 4u/c^2$ (monic). Conversely, given a split or special linear $d_2 = u - a$ ($\chi(a) = 1$ or $a = 0$) and $c \in \mathbb{F}_q^\times$, put $d' = (u - a)^2 - 4u/c^2$; then $s_{d'} \equiv -cd_2/2$ is a square root of u modulo d' (as $(cd_2/2)^2 \equiv u$), every prime of d' is split, d' is coprime to d_2 (its value at $u = a$ is $-4a/c^2 \neq 0$ for $a \neq 0$; for $a = 0$, $d' = u^2 - 4u/c^2$ is divisible by u , so $a = 0$ is excluded, losing $O(q)$ of the $O(q^2)$ configurations), and d' is squarefree unless its discriminant $(16/c^2)(a + 1/c^2)$ vanishes, i.e. unless $a = -1/c^2$ ($O(q)$ configurations). For each admissible (d_2, c) and each of the $\omega(d_2) = 2$ choices of s_{d_2} there is exactly one ordered pair with difference cd_2 ; the pairs with difference $-cd_2$ are those of $(d_2, -c)$, which gives the same d' . Hence

$$\begin{aligned} T_{\text{act}}(2) &= \sum_{(d_2, c) \text{ admissible}} 2W_f(d_2 d') = 2P(1) \sum \frac{\lambda(d_2)\lambda(d')}{q^3} \\ &= \frac{2}{q^3} \left(\frac{q-1}{2}\right)(q-1)(1 + O(q^{-1})) = \frac{1}{q} + O\left(\frac{1}{q^2}\right). \end{aligned}$$

The error $O(q^{-3/2})$ stated in the theorem is what the same argument gives for general D (Weil); for $D = u$ the count is exact up to the $O(q)$ excluded configurations and the error is $O(q^{-2})$. $\square$

Remark 23 (the random permutation model). The leading term of $T_{\text{exp}}(N)$ is

$$q^N \sum_{\deg d=N+1} \omega^\circ(d) q^{-2(N+1)} = q^{-1} \mathbb{E}_{N+1}[\omega^2 - \omega],$$

the expectation over monic d of degree $N+1$. As $q \rightarrow \infty$ the factorisation type of a random d of degree k is distributed like the cycle type of a random permutation in S_k , and χ_D takes the values ± 1 independently and equiprobably on the prime factors (Weil), so that $\omega(d) = 2^{\#\{P|d\}}$ if all factors are split and 0 otherwise, whence $\mathbb{E}_k[\omega] = 1$ and $\mathbb{E}_k[\omega^2] = \mathbb{E}[2^{\text{cycles}}] = (k+1)!/k! = k+1$. Thus $T_{\text{exp}}(N) \rightarrow (N+1)/q$ for every N and every D , in agreement with $2/q$ and $3/q$ above, and the theorem says $T_{\text{act}}(N) \rightarrow (N-1)/q$ for $N=1, 2$.

Remark 24 (configuration count). The proof of Theorem 22 generalises to a heuristic for every N and D . A pair of distinct roots modulo d with difference m of degree $i \leq N-1$ is a configuration (d_2, μ, d') : $d_2 \mid d$ monic of degree $j \leq i$ on which the roots agree, $m = d_2 \mu$, $\deg \mu = i-j$, and $d' \mid m^2 - 4D$ of degree k , with $d = d_2 d'$, $\deg d = j+k \in (N, M(N)]$. Weighted by $W_f(d) \asymp q^{-(j+k)}$ and by the $\omega(d_2)$ choices of the root on d_2 , and using that $\sum_{\deg d_2=j} \omega(d_2) \sim q^j$, that there are $\sim q^{i-j+1}$ polynomials μ , and that a polynomial of degree n has on average exactly one monic divisor of each degree $k \leq n$ (for the family $m^2 - 4D$ this is the equidistribution of the roots of $x^2 \equiv 4D$ among the residues of low degree, i.e. the function-field Hypothesis (E) itself), the configuration (j, i, k) contributes $\asymp q^{i+1-j-k}$. The exponent is ≤ -1 with equality exactly when $i = N-1$ and $k = N+1-j$ (moduli of degree $N+1$), subject to $k \leq \deg(m^2 - 4D) = \max(2N-2, \deg D)$. Hence

$$\begin{aligned} T_{\text{act}}(N) &\rightarrow \frac{c_N(D)}{q}, \\ c_N(D) &= \#\{j \in [0, N-1] : N+1-j \leq \max(2N-2, \deg D)\} \\ &= \min(N, \max(2N-2, \deg D) - 1), \end{aligned}$$

while $T_{\text{exp}}(N) \rightarrow (N+1)/q$ by Remark 23. For $D = u$: $c_1 = 0$, $c_2 = 1$, in agreement with the theorem; $c_N = N$ for $N \geq 3$. The generic value $c_N = N$ leaves $\text{Off}_f(N) \rightarrow -1/q$, and $1/q = q^N \sum_{\deg d=N+1} a_f(d)/|d|$ is exactly the weight that the excluded diagonal pairs ($s = s'$, the “configuration $j = N$ ”) would carry at degree $N+1$: the off-diagonal cancels the first term of the diagonal tail.

Conjecture 25. *For every squarefree D of positive degree and every $N \geq 1$,*

$$\text{Off}_f(N) = -\frac{N+1-c_N(D)}{q} + O\left(\frac{1}{q^{3/2}}\right) \quad (q \rightarrow \infty),$$

with $c_N(D)$ as in Remark 24; in particular $\text{Off}_f(N) = -1/q + O(q^{-3/2})$ for all $N \geq 3$, and for $N \leq 2$ unless $\deg D \leq N$, where it is $-2/q + O(q^{-3/2})$.

Table 1 and Figure 1 give the exact values for $D = u, u^2 + 1, u^3 + u$ (`research/paper-III/scripts/offq.ts`). They agree with the conjecture in every case: $q \text{Off}_f(N)$ is near -2 for $(N, \deg D) = (1, 1), (2, 1), (2, 2)$ and near -1 for $(1, 2), (1, 3), (2, 3)$; for $(3, 1)$ with all moduli only $q \leq 7$ is available and the values $-4.9, -2.5, -2.0$ are still descending. Since the main term comes from the moduli of degree $N+1$ alone (the others contribute $O(q^{-2})$), the leading constant can be tested at larger q by restricting T_{act} to that degree: for $D = u^2 + 1$, $N = 3$ (degree 4), $q T_{\text{act}}$ is $2.5, 2.4, 2.9$ and $q \text{Off}_f$ is $-1.06, -1.08, -1.20$ at $q = 13, 17, 19$, against the predicted $c_3 = 3$ and -1 ; for $D = u$, $N = 4$ (degree 5), $q T_{\text{act}} = 3.9$, $q T_{\text{exp}} = 5.6$, $q \text{Off}_f = -1.6$ at $q = 11$, against $c_4 = 4, 5$ and -1 (with the same slow $1/q$ approach as at $N = 1$). The fluctuations grow with

Table 1: $q \text{Off}_f(N)$, $q T_{\text{act}}(N)$ and $q T_{\text{exp}}(N)$ for $f = t^2 - D$ over $\mathbb{F}_q[u]$, the three largest q computed. Predicted limits (Conjecture 25, Remarks 23, 24): $q T_{\text{exp}} \rightarrow N + 1$, $q T_{\text{act}} \rightarrow c_N(D)$.

D	N	q	$q \text{Off}_f(N)$	$q T_{\text{act}}$	$q T_{\text{exp}}$	predicted limit
u	1	37, 41, 43	-2.15, -2.13, -2.13	0, 0, 0	2.15, 2.13, 2.13	-2
u	2	37, 41, 43	-2.08, -2.08, -2.02	1.06, 1.05, 1.10	3.14, 3.13, 3.12	-2
u	3	3, 5, 7	-4.91, -2.50, -2.02	—	—	-1
$u^2 + 1$	1	37, 41, 43	-1.02, -1.02, -1.12	0.97, 0.98, 0.98	2.00, 2.00, 2.10	-1
$u^2 + 1$	2	37, 41, 43	-1.97, -1.97, -2.07	0.94, 0.95, 1.00	2.91, 2.92, 3.07	-2
$u^3 + u$	1	17, 19, 23	-1.00, -1.36, -1.17	0.69, 1.01, 1.13	1.70, 2.37, 2.30	-1
$u^3 + u$	2	17, 19, 23	-0.79, -1.31, -1.26	1.68, 2.16, 2.13	2.47, 3.47, 3.38	-1

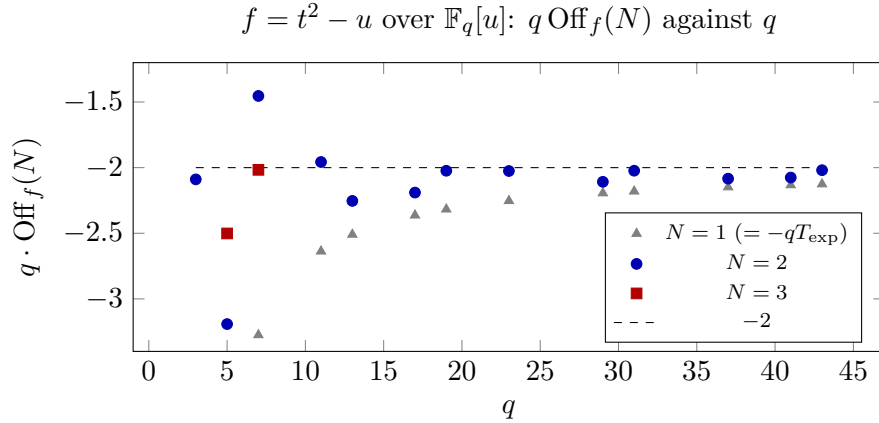


Figure 1: Exact values of $q \text{Off}_f(N)$ for $f = t^2 - u$ (research/paper-III/scripts/offq.ts; $N = 3$ needs all squarefree moduli of degree ≤ 6 and was computed for $q \leq 7$). Theorem 22 gives the limit -2 for $N = 1, 2$; Conjecture 25 predicts -1 for $N = 3$. The $N = 1$ values approach -2 from below like $-2 - 5/q$.

$\deg D$, as they should: the prime counts carry Weil terms $O(q^{k/2})$ from an L -function of degree $\deg D - 1$, which is trivial for $D = u$.

In words. Over $\mathbb{F}_q[u]$ the off-diagonal is not just bounded: it has a main term of exact size $1/q$, with a computable coefficient. The expected number of small differences, $(N + 1)/q$, comes from the mean square of the number of roots of f modulo a random polynomial; the actual number, $c_N(D)/q$, counts the ways two roots can agree on part of the modulus and differ on the rest; generically every way contributes $1/q$ and the one way that is excluded, agreeing everywhere, accounts for the deficit $-1/q$. It is the first main term for the off-diagonal in the programme, and it has the same origin as the constant $c_{\text{off}}(f)$ of Theorem 12 over $\mathbb{Z}$: both measure the gap between the discrete count of root differences and its continuous expectation, and both are negative. Over $\mathbb{Z}$ the gap sits at the moduli $d \asymp H$ (the pieces with $u \asymp H$); over $\mathbb{F}_q[u]$ it sits at degree $N + 1$.

7 What remains

1. The window $\mathcal{W}_u(Y; L)$ for $1 < u \leq H^{2/3}$ (Theorem 14). Through Hypothesis W this asks for a power saving in the Weyl sums of the dilated roots $u^2 x^2 \equiv D$ on average over the modulus with a loss below $(uk)^{(1-\theta)/6}$ in the frequency $k \leq u^2 \log H$ and the dilation u (Remark 20); the route is Hooley's parametrisation with the discriminant $4u^2 D$, or the half-integral-weight Kuznetsov formula for $\Gamma_0(4u^2)$ as in [1], and in either case the dependence on the frequency and the level is the whole question. A different route would avoid Weyl sums altogether: the pieces are divisor-type sums $\sum_{h \leq Y} (Y - h)(F_u(Q_u(h)) - \mathbb{E}F_u)$ (Remark 21), and an averaging over u in short ranges, combining the mechanisms of Theorems 6 and 12, would also extend the range $2/3$ of Theorem 12 towards $1/2$ and relax the condition to $\theta + 3B < 1$.
2. The constant: Theorem 14 identifies c_{off} only up to the logarithmic loss of the small moduli. A power saving in Theorem 6, i.e. in Proposition 4, is not available (the Kowalski–Soundararajan method saves a power of log only); so “ $\text{Off}_f^*(H) = c_{\text{off}}H + o(H)$ ” unconditionally needs the small moduli of every piece to be treated by Weyl sums as well, which is again Hypothesis W.
3. A sharp-cut-off version of [1] with $(\theta, B) = (\frac{3}{4}, \frac{1}{4})$, which would improve the exponent in Theorem 9.
4. Conjecture 25, by the Lang–Weil count of the configurations (d_2, μ, d') of Remark 24; the only input beyond counting is the equidistribution of the roots of $x^2 \equiv 4D$ modulo d' among the residues of degree $< \deg d' - 1$, at the first sub-leading order, which is the function-field Hypothesis (E) at moduli of degree $N + 1$. A proof for $N = 3$, $D = u$ (moduli of degree 4) would already decide between the two constants.
5. The same programme for Galois groups that are not 2-transitive, where the decomposition into pieces has several orbit types and a saving over the trivial bound is not enough (part I, Remark 7).

A Computations

The script `offq.ts` in `research/paper-III/scripts/` computes $T_{\text{act}}(N)$ and $T_{\text{exp}}(N)$ exactly from the roots modulo every squarefree d of degree in $(N, M(N)]$ (the finite-support lemma of part I), for $f = t^2 - D$ with D given by the environment variable

D ; the data for $D = u$ ($N \leq 2$ for the primes $q \leq 43$, $N \leq 3$ for $q \leq 7$) are in `research/paper-III/data/offq*.dat`. The runs for $D = u^2 + 1$ ($q \leq 43$) and $D = u^3 + u$ ($q \leq 23$) are in `research/paper-III/data/offq-D2.log`, `research/paper-III/data/offq-D3.log` and the tables `research/paper-III/data/offq-D*-table.dat`. Over $\mathbb{Z}$ the exact off-diagonal of $t^2 + 1$ to 10^7 is in part II, Section 5.3.

AI-assisted research: disclosure

This work was carried out with heavy use of large language models, the Anthropic models Claude Fable 5.1 and Claude Opus 5, used interactively by the author in September 2026 as research assistants. The author posed the questions, set the direction and the scope, and made every decision about what to pursue, claim and submit. The model was used to draft mathematical arguments, to write and run the software behind every number in the paper, to search the literature, and to draft the text; all of this was done in dialogue with the author, who verified the code and the numerical results, reviewed the proofs, and takes full responsibility for the content. The model is not an author. The complete record of the work, including the code, the data, a chronological knowledge base listing the errors made and corrected along the way, and the review passes, is in the public repository <https://github.com/gewure/ulamnd> (directory `research/`), so that the extent and the nature of the assistance can be checked in detail.

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